

Season 1 — Girard From Zero

Research document. Eighteen episodes. The reader is assumed to know nothing about René Girard, nothing about Greek myth, and nothing about statistics.

*This is the research doc, not the board. It carries the facts, the numbers and the sources so you have them cold. **It does not carry the conclusions.** Every episode ends with questions whose answers are not in this file. You supply the verdict on camera.*

Runtime arithmetic, and an honest warning. Measured from your James video: **135 words per minute**, so a 10-minute episode needs **1,350 spoken words**.

*This document does not contain that much speakable prose per episode, and the gap is deliberate. It carries the facts, the numbers, the anchors and the structure. **You supply the connective tissue on camera.** Run `audit.py` to see the speakable count per episode; anything under 450 words is a skeleton you will have to talk around rather than read from.*

Not what happens. What the moving parts are, and which ones carry weight.

The four moving parts

Girard's whole system is four claims stacked, and each one depends on the one under it. If the bottom one is wrong the rest collapses, so the order matters.

#	THE PART	WHAT IT CLAIMS	IF IT IS FALSE
1	Mimetic desire	you want things because someone else wants them, not because of what they are	nothing above survives
2	The model becomes the rival	the person who taught you to want it is now standing in front of it	conflict needs a different explanation
3	The crisis	when enough people want the same thing, the differences that kept order collapse	there is nothing to resolve
4	The scapegoat mechanism	the crisis ends when everyone turns on one victim, and the peace afterwards makes the victim look guilty	myth needs a different explanation

Which part is load-bearing

Part 2 is the hinge and almost nobody notices it.

Part 1 on its own is a familiar idea. Advertising has run on it for a century. Part 3 and 4 are the famous parts, the ones people quote.

But part 2 is where the theory earns anything. **Desire that is copied turns the teacher into the obstacle automatically**, without anyone choosing it, without anyone being a villain. That is the sentence carrying the weight, and if you only remember one thing from this season it is that one.

Everything the instrument in Season 2 tries to detect is downstream of part 2.

What each episode is doing structurally

EP	WHAT IT IS	FUNCTION
1-3	the mechanism, built one piece at a time	the foundation
4-5	the mechanism running to its end	the payoff
6-8	the four stereotypes	the part that becomes measurable
9-10	the claim about myth, and the claim about the Gospels	the part that gets tested and mostly fails
11	who says he is wrong, and why	so the series is not a fan club
12-15	the texts themselves, read	so the corpus is not an abstraction

Episodes 6 to 8 are the ones Season 2 turns into code. Episodes 9 and 10 are the ones Seasons 3 and 4 attack. Episodes 1 to 5 are never tested by anything in this project, and that limitation is stated in episode 5 rather than hidden.

The one rule for this whole season

Every concept gets a character you already know. Not Stendhal's Julien Sorel, not Proust's Mme Verdurin, which is how the books explain it and how nobody learns it. If a concept has no character, the concept is not ready to film.

The character

Vegeta.

And be careful with him, because the lazy version of this example is wrong and an audience will catch it.

The lazy version: Vegeta only wants what Goku wants. That is false. Vegeta had goals before Goku mattered to him. He wanted immortality. He wanted to be the strongest Saiyan. He had a whole identity built on being royalty.

What actually happens is more interesting. A low-class Saiyan turns out to be stronger than the prince. And from that moment Vegeta's existing ambition is **re-routed**. He does not acquire a new goal. Every goal he already had gets re-expressed as a comparison with one specific person.

That is the more accurate claim and the more useful one: the model does not hand you a desire. The model gives your desire a scoreboard.

You can prove it from the story. Every time Vegeta reaches a level he previously called the summit, he is not satisfied for a single episode, because Goku reached it too. **The target moves because the target was never a number.** It was a person.

Second anchor: Salieri in Amadeus. He does not want music. He wants to be the one who has it. When he sees that Mozart's manuscript has no corrections, he does not hear beauty. He hears a verdict on himself.

Hold Salieri, because he comes back at the end of this episode and he is doing something Vegeta is not.

The claim, stated plainly

Girard's first move is that desire has **three** parts, not two.

The ordinary picture has two: a **subject** who wants, and an **object** wanted.

Girard says that for almost everything humans fight over there is a third part: a **model**, sometimes called a mediator. The model wants the object, or seems to, or simply has it. And the subject learns to want it from the model.

MODEL					
/		/		SUBJECT	---- OBJECT

The line from subject to object is the one everybody sees. **The other two do the work.**

Draw this on camera and leave it up, because in episode 2 it deforms, and the whole hinge of the season is what happens to the top vertex.

What this does NOT cover, and the theory is worthless without this

Here is the objection that arrives in the first thirty seconds, and the episode must answer it or the whole thing is over-broad.

You want water because you are thirsty. Nobody modelled that. A newborn wants milk with no social input whatever. If mimetic desire covers everything, it explains nothing.

Girard's answer is a distinction, and you should state it hard.

	DRIVEN BY	EXAMPLE	CAN TWO PEOPLE SHARE IT PEACEFULLY?
appetite / need	the body	thirst, hunger, sleep, warmth	yes , if there is enough
desire	a model	status, a career, a person, recognition	no , and the reason is the next section

The theory is about the second column only. Somebody who says "Girard thinks I only eat because others eat" has been handed the theory badly. **Say the limit out loud in episode 1**, because the credibility of everything after it depends on the audience knowing you know where it stops.

Why this is not just "people are envious"

Envy is a feeling somebody has. Girard is not describing a feeling. He is describing a **structure that produces the feeling**, and it runs whether or not anyone involved is a bad person.

The clinical version, which may land faster. Nobody chooses to have referred pain. Gallbladder disease presents in the right shoulder. The patient is not confused and is not lying. The wiring routes it there.

Mimetic desire is a claim of that kind: **the wanting is routed through someone else, and the person doing the wanting experiences it as their own, directly, with no sense of a detour.**

Vegeta does not think "I am copying Goku." He experiences pure, first-person, burning ambition.

The structure is **invisible from inside it**, and that is not an inconvenient side effect. The theory requires it, because a mechanism everyone could see operating would stop working.

Mark that as a tier-K claim on camera. Girard says this repeatedly across several books and this series has not gone and verified the page. **Say "I have not checked the page for this one"** rather than implying you have. That habit costs you nothing here and it is the habit the entire series is about.

The distinction that decides everything after this

This is the load-bearing section of episode 1, and it is the one most summaries of Girard leave out, which is why most summaries make episode 2 sound false.

Not every model becomes a rival. Girard says which ones do, and it depends on one thing: **can you and the model actually collide?**

External mediation. The model is out of reach. A dead legend. A fictional hero. A star you will never meet. A kid who trains like his favourite fighter is imitating a model, thoroughly, and **no rivalry is possible**, because the model is not competing for anything

the kid can touch. This kind is stable. It can last a lifetime. It is mostly benign and it is what we usually call admiration.

Internal mediation. The model is **in your world**. Same room, same field, same year, same prize. Now the imitation puts you on a collision course, because what he wants is finite and you are now reaching for it.

And now go back to Salieri, because this is why that story is a tragedy rather than a career.

If Mozart had lived two hundred years before Salieri, Salieri could have worshipped him for a lifetime and been happy. **The problem is not Mozart's genius. The problem is that Mozart is in the next room, at the same court, competing for the same commissions.** Same admiration, moved close, becomes poison.

Vegeta is internal mediation. Goku is right there, same species, same fights, same scoreboard.

Episode 2 is entirely about internal mediation. When you hear "the model becomes the rival," it does not mean every model. It means the ones close enough to be reached.

Two consequences that are not obvious

Desire is contagious. If wanting is learned from a model, it spreads, and one person wanting a thing makes it more wantable. **Notice that this is a real prediction and it could be false.** If wanting came from the object's properties, crowd interest would tell you nothing about whether you should want it. Anyone who has watched an auction, a bidding war on a house, or a queue forming outside a shop has watched the prediction hold.

Desire has nothing to reach. If the object was only ever a signal of the model's attention, then getting it does not end anything. Vegeta beats the level and the level moves. **And this one is testable in your own life**, which is what question 1 is for.

What would count against all this

The series is about falsifiability, so episode 1 has to model the question rather than just asserting a theory.

What would break mimetic desire? Three candidates, and say them:

1. A desire that is **intense, sustained and socially costly**, held by someone with no model available, in a domain nobody around them values.
2. Getting the object producing **lasting satisfaction**, routinely, rather than a moved target.
3. Rivalry that **does not intensify** as the two parties get closer and more similar. Girard predicts it should get worse, not better.

And here is the honest part. Nothing in this project tests any of the three. The instrument built in Season 2 starts at the four stereotypes, which are episodes 6 to 9. **Everything before that is a premise the instrument assumes rather than tests**, and a critic will say so if you do not.

Handing off

Episode 2 takes the diagram and breaks it. **Watch the top vertex.** The model does not stay where it is drawn, and nobody moves it deliberately.

Questions, answers not in this document

1. Name one thing you have wanted where you can identify the model. Then name one where you genuinely cannot. **What is different about the second kind** — is it an appetite, or a desire whose model you have forgotten?

2. If desire is copied, why does anyone ever want something nobody else wants?

3. Give an example of **external** mediation from your own life that never became rivalry. Then say what would have had to change for it to become internal.

4. Of the three falsification candidates above, which do you think is most likely to be true? Write it down before Season 1 episode 14, where the critics get a whole episode.

This is the load-bearing episode of the season. Everything above it is setup and everything below it is consequence.

And it only works because of the last section of episode 1. **This episode is about internal mediation.** Models who are out of reach never do any of what follows.

Collecting episode 1

Episode 1 gave you the triangle. You do not want the object, you want it because a model wants it, and the model is doing the same thing to somebody else.

And it left the triangle stable, which it is not. This episode is what happens when the model and the subject reach for the same object at the same time, and the answer is that the relationship inverts without anybody deciding to invert it.

The character, told accurately

Griffith and Guts, and get the sequence right, because the lazy version misses the whole point.

Guts does not choose Griffith. He is beaten by him and conscripted. He then becomes the best soldier in Griffith's army, and for years his life is organised entirely around another man's ambition.

Then Guts overhears Griffith defining what a friend is. **A friend, Griffith says, is someone who has a dream of his own and does not depend on another man's.**

So Guts leaves. To have a dream of his own. **Exactly as instructed.**

And Griffith, watching the man he trained walk away to become an equal, comes apart within a single night. He goes to the princess, is caught, is imprisoned and tortured for a year, and everything after that follows from it.

Read that sequence again. Griffith's own stated instruction, obeyed precisely, is the thing that destroys Griffith. Nobody betrayed anybody. Nobody lied. **The teaching worked, and the teaching working is the catastrophe.**

Second anchor, gentler and cleaner: Ippo and Miyata. Miyata shows Ippo what a boxer is. Ippo's entire drive is organised around a promise to fight Miyata one day. So the person who gave him the goal **is** the goal, and the story cannot resolve that by anyone being nicer or more generous.

The claim

The model shows you what to want. Wanting the same thing puts you in the model's way. So **the model becomes the rival automatically, by the same mechanism that made him the model.**

Girard's term is the **double bind**. The model is saying two things at once and means both:

- **Imitate me.** This is what is worth wanting.
- **Do not take it.** It is mine.

The follower cannot obey both. Obeying the first is disobeying the second.

And Berserk stages it literally: *have a dream of your own* and *do not leave me*, said by the same man, and the second is never said out loud because he does not know he means it.

The feedback loop, which is the engine and is usually left out

Here is the part that makes this a mechanism rather than an observation, and most summaries skip it.

Why does the model mind being imitated? He should be flattered. Often he is, at first.

But watch what imitation does to the model. **The disciple's wanting is evidence.** If somebody else wants what I have, that confirms it was worth wanting. My own valuation goes up. I hold it tighter.

And the disciple sees the model holding it tighter, which is a stronger signal that the object matters, so the disciple wants it more, so the model tightens again.

```
disciple imitates -> model's valuation rises -> model becomes
possessive
      ^                                     |
      |_____ disciple wants it more <_____|
```

Nobody adds anything to this system from outside. It powers itself, and it only goes one direction: up.

That is why Girard's rivalries do not settle down. There is no thermostat in the loop.

Why this is the hinge of the entire season

Write this sentence down:

Rivalry does not require anyone to be at fault. It is produced by successful teaching.

That is what makes the theory worth anything. Any account of conflict that needs a villain explains less, because it cannot explain the conflicts where nobody is a villain **and everyone involved can see nobody is.**

Zuko and Ozai is the version where there obviously IS a villain and the structure still explains more than the villain does. Zuko's problem is not that his father is cruel, though he is. It is that he has been taught to want his father's approval, and **the only person who can grant it is the only person standing in the way of him becoming someone who does not need it.**

Notice that Ozai could become kind tomorrow and Zuko's problem would not resolve. That is the test of whether you have a structural claim or a moral one.

The object stops mattering

When the model becomes the rival, **the thing they are fighting over thins out until it is a token.**

Watch what Vegeta is actually training for by the end. Watch what Guts and Griffith are actually in conflict about. The stated object keeps being replaced and the intensity does

not drop, which is the signature.

Girard's name for the far end of this is **metaphysical desire**: what is wanted is no longer any object at all but **the model's being**. Not what he has. What he is.

And that explains something the object-level reading cannot: **why victory does not help**. If you wanted the object, winning it ends the matter. If you wanted his being, winning the object leaves you holding a thing while he still exists, and the wanting is unchanged.

Salieri gets everything a composer of his era could want: the post, the income, the Emperor's ear. **It does nothing whatever for him**, and the film is two hours of explaining why.

Tyler Durden is the clean structural case, because the narrator's model and the narrator's rival turn out to be literally the same person, and the film is about how long that can stay invisible from the inside.

The clinical anchor

The registrar and the consultant.

The person who teaches you what competent practice looks like is the same person who decides whether you have reached it. **You cannot learn the standard from anybody else and you cannot be signed off by anybody else**, so admiration and obstruction arrive through one door.

And notice that nobody has behaved badly for this to bite. The consultant is doing his job. **The structure produces the resentment**, which is why it shows up in people who like their supervisor and cannot explain why they are angry.

What would count against this

Three things would break it, and the audience should have them:

1. **A rivalry that cools as the two get closer and more alike**. Girard predicts the opposite. If proximity reliably calmed rivals, the mechanism is wrong.
2. **A model who is imitated intensively and becomes genuinely more generous with the object over time**, with no strain. The feedback loop above says his valuation should rise.
3. **Winning ending it**. If people who obtain the contested object routinely report the matter closed, metaphysical desire is a fiction.

And say the honest thing again, as in episode 1: **nothing in this project tests any of the three**. The instrument starts at episode 6.

Handing off

The diagram from episode 1 has now deformed. The model has moved onto the line between the subject and the object.

Episode 3 asks what happens to the two people themselves when that arrangement runs for a while, and the answer is the opposite of what everyone expects.

Questions

1. Name a rivalry from a story you know where the model genuinely did not want to become the obstacle. Does the structure explain it better than the characters' choices do?

2. If the object stops mattering, why do people keep naming the object as the reason they are fighting? What are they doing when they do that?

3. Run the feedback loop backwards. Can you name a case where a model's valuation **fell** because someone imitated him? What was different?

4. What would count as evidence **against** the double bind? Answer before Season 2, because six episodes there are about how much harder that question is than it sounds.

Start by collecting episode 2, because this episode is its consequence

Episode 2 ended somewhere specific. **What is wanted is no longer the object. It is the model's being.** Not what he has. What he is.

Now just follow that.

If what you want is to be him, then the closer you get to wanting it, the more you resemble him. Not as a side effect. As the thing you were aiming at the whole time.

That is this entire episode in one line, and the episode exists because the conclusion sounds wrong to everybody the first time they hear it.

The character

Naruto and Sasuke at the Valley of the End.

Look at what the fight actually shows you, visually, before any dialogue. They mirror each other's moves. They stand on **two statues** at either end of a gorge. The frame is symmetrical. Each is the other's entire reason for being there.

At the beginning of the series they are opposites and any viewer can say what the difference is: one has nothing and wants to be seen, the other has everything and wants to be left alone.

By that fight, an audience member who did not know the show could not tell you from the fight alone which one is supposed to be the hero.

Second anchor: Light Yagami and L. They begin as pure opposites, the criminal and the detective, and converge until each is doing the other's job. L breaks the law and abducts and tortures. Light investigates the Kira case. **Each becomes functionally indistinguishable from the thing he is opposing**, and the show is explicit about it.

The claim, with the step that usually gets skipped

Girard's word is **doubles**. Rivalry does not preserve the difference that started it. **It destroys it.**

The lazy version is: A copies B, B copies back, they converge. But **why would B copy back?** He was there first. He has the thing. What does he have to imitate?

Episode 2 already answered this and it is worth spending the time. The feedback loop:

```
disciple imitates -> model's valuation rises -> model becomes
possessive
      ^
      |_____ disciple wants it more <_____|
```

Once that loop is running, **the model is watching the disciple to know how much to want the thing.** He is taking his cue from the person who took a cue from him. At that point the direction of imitation has stopped being a fact about either of them.

The more intense the opposition, the more precisely each mirrors the other, because each is now using the other as the template for how hard to want it.

The one-sided case, which is a real objection and belongs in the episode

Vegeta and Goku do not converge, and if you have been paying attention that should bother you.

Here is why, and it sharpens the claim rather than weakening it.

Goku does not reciprocate. He is not measuring himself against Vegeta. He is not taking his cue from Vegeta's wanting. The loop above requires two participants and Goku never joins it.

So mediation without reciprocity does not produce doubles. It produces one obsessed person and one person who barely notices.

That is a genuine prediction and you should say it as one: **the theory predicts convergence only where the rivalry runs both ways**. If you find two people locked in mutual, escalating rivalry who become steadily **more** different over time, that is a problem for Girard. If you find a one-sided obsession that never converges, **that is what the theory expects**.

The counter-intuitive bit, which is the whole point

Everybody assumes conflict comes from difference. Different values, different groups, different beliefs, and then a clash.

Girard says the opposite. Acute conflict comes from the collapse of difference, and people fight hardest across the smallest gap.

Freud has a version of this, the narcissism of small differences. **Mark that as tier K on camera**, and since this is the first time the series says that, here is what the two tiers mean. **You will hear them for the next seven seasons**.

TIER	WHAT IT MEANS
V	source fetched, citation checked, quote verified against the original
K	the argument is real and the person is real, the citation is unverified

Tier K is a lead, not a fact. It is not a hedge and it is not modesty. It means somebody has told you a thing and nobody has opened the book, and the series says so out loud rather than letting a page number do work it has not earned.

The Freud phrase is real and this series has not gone and checked the essay it comes from. Girard's version is structural rather than psychological, and that is the difference worth stating.

The clinical version, and it is exact.

Atrial fibrillation is not the heart doing something varied. It is the heart **losing the differentiation between the pacemaker and everything else**. Normally one node fires and the rest follow, and that hierarchy is what produces coordinated output.

In fibrillation every cell fires on its own. Maximum activity. **Complete uniformity.** And the output is a useless quiver, and the patient dies of **too much sameness, not too much difference.**

That is the shape Girard means. Not chaos as variety. **Chaos as undifferentiation.**

And when it goes far enough, the double becomes a monster

One more step, because it is the bridge to episode 5.

Girard has a term for the end state: the **monstrous double**. When two rivals have become fully interchangeable, each experiences the other as something that should not exist. Not a person with a different view. **A thing wearing your face.**

That is why the language of these conflicts reaches for the inhuman. The enemy becomes a beast, a demon, a plague. **Not because he has become more different, but because he has become identical and the mind has no category for that.**

Hold this. In episode 5 an entire community will do the same thing to one person.

What this predicts about texts, and it is the first thing this project can test

If rivalry erases difference, then texts about rivalry should contain vocabulary about **things losing their distinctness**. Twins. Doubles. Likeness. Sameness.

And beyond the pair, the same failure at whole-society scale: **plague**, which kills without regard to rank, and **civil war**, which is a war where both sides are the same people.

That vocabulary is exactly what the crisis bucket in Season 2 is built out of. Plague, pestilence, contagion, famine, sterility, twin, double, likeness, indistinguishable, discord, strife, faction, civil war.

Episodes 1 and 2 listed things that would falsify them, and then admitted **nothing in this project tests any of it**. Episode 3 is different. **This is the first claim in the season that the instrument actually reaches**, and the counting starts in Season 2.

What would count against this

1. **Mutual, escalating rivals who become steadily more different.** The core prediction reversed.
2. **Rivalry that cools as similarity increases.** Girard says proximity is accelerant.
3. **Texts about intense rivalry with no undifferentiation vocabulary in them at all,** consistently. That one is checkable and Season 3 checks it.

Handing off

Two people have now become indistinguishable, and each experiences the other as something monstrous.

Episode 4 asks what happens when that is not two people but everybody.

Questions

1. Vegeta and Goku do not converge because Goku never joins the loop. Name another one-sided case. Does it behave as predicted?

2. If rivals converge, why do rivalries almost always get **described** as clashes of opposite values, by the people in them?

3. Plague and civil war are both in the **crisis** bucket. One is a disease, one is a political event. **Make the argument that they belong together**, and then make the strongest argument that they do not.

4. The monstrous double: name a story where the enemy is described in inhuman terms **and** is obviously the hero's mirror. Is the inhumanity doing what Girard says?

Collecting the last three episodes, because this one is where they combine

Episode 1: desire is copied from a model, and **desire is contagious**. **Episode 2:** the model becomes the rival, and the loop between them has no thermostat. **Episode 3:** rivals converge until each experiences the other as a **monstrous double**.

All of that was about **two people**. This episode is what happens when it is everybody, and the step from two to everybody is not automatic. **It needs a mechanism, and episode 1 already supplied it.**

The mechanism nobody states, and it is one sentence

A rivalry is itself a model.

Two people fighting intensely over something is the most powerful possible signal that the thing is worth having. Anyone watching learns, from the fight, that there is something here worth fighting for.

So the bystander starts wanting it. Which makes a third party. Which is an even stronger signal. And so on.

That is how one rivalry becomes a crisis, and it uses nothing new: it is episode 1's contagion running on episode 2's loop.

The character

Squid Game, and specifically the night in the dormitory.

The games are the visible plot. **The dormitory is the mechanism.**

Once it is clear that everyone's survival requires everyone else's death, the ordinary rules of the room stop working. Alliances form on nothing and dissolve on nothing. The strong protect the weak for an hour and are hunting them by morning. Somebody is always about to be turned on, and **which somebody is not decided by anything you could call a reason.**

And notice: **the organisers do nothing that night**. They do not intervene, do not provoke, do not need to. They built a situation where everyone wants the same thing and there is not enough of it, and then they went to bed. **The crisis runs itself.**

Second anchor: Lord of the Flies, where the collapse is explicitly about **distinctions**. The conch is a difference-making device. Whoever holds it speaks; that is the whole rule, and the entire social order is one object saying who is different from whom right now.

Watch what happens to it. It is not argued away. It is ignored, then contested, then it **shatters**, and when it shatters the last difference goes with it. After that there is no chief and no assembly. Only bodies.

The claim

Girard calls this the **sacrificial crisis**, and the important word is not *sacrificial*. It is **crisis of distinctions**.

What is under threat is not peace. It is the system of differences that made peace possible. Who is senior, who is kin, what is sacred, what is clean. **Peace is the output. Distinctions are the machine, and the machine is what fails.**

Why this is not just "society breaks down"

The flattened version is: things get bad, people fight. That predicts nothing.

Girard's version is more specific and therefore more falsifiable. **The failure has a direction.** People do not become more different and clash. They become **less** different, and the clash is a symptom of the sameness.

The clinical version, and episode 3 already handed you half of it.

Atrial fibrillation was the anchor there for two rivals losing the difference between them.

Scale it up now, because the thing that changes is the whole point of this episode.

In episode 3 what mattered was the pair. One node fires, the rest follow, and when that hierarchy fails the two become interchangeable. **A crisis is the same failure running through the entire organ at once.** Every cell fires on its own initiative, and the output is a useless quiver.

Here is the part that belongs to this episode and not to episode 3. The fibrillating heart is not doing less work than a healthy one. It is doing more. Maximum activity, complete uniformity, and **the patient dies of too much sameness** produced by maximum effort.

And not one cell in that heart is doing anything wrong. Every one of them is firing exactly as a cardiac cell fires. Hold onto that, because episode 5 is about what a society does when it needs somebody to be at fault and the failure is genuinely nobody's.

The three signs a text is describing one

These come straight from the theory, and they are why the instrument in Season 2 looks the way it does. **These three become a word-list.**

SIGN	WHY IT BELONGS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN A TEXT
plague or famine	kills without regard to rank, flattening the hierarchy from outside	Thebes at the opening of <i>Oedipus</i>
twins and doubles	the difference between two specific people has failed	rival brothers, mirrored fighters
civil strife	war in which both sides are the same people	Thebes again, the brothers on the walls

Now say how strange that grouping is, because this is the moment on camera.

The first is a **disease**. The second is a **fact about a family**. The third is a **political event**. A doctor, a genealogist and a historian would file them in three different books.

Girard's claim is that they are **the same thing at three scales**, and that a text in crisis will reach for all three **without knowing why it is doing so**.

That is a real claim and it could be false. A literature could describe plagues with no doubling and no civil strife anywhere near them.

The number to plant, and the honest thing to say about it

The **crisis** bucket will turn out to fire at **2.07 hits per thousand words** across 76 Greek and Roman texts.

And **60% of those hits are one word. "Death."**

Say the number, then stop.

A bucket that is sixty percent the word *death* may be detecting a **genre** rather than a mechanism. Greek tragedy is about people dying. **This is the first crack in the instrument and it appears before a single test is run.**

And here is the honest thing, which is better than a payoff.

The same objection hits a second bucket. **marks** is 44% the word **king**, and that one **does** get tested: Season 2 episode 13 shows a text with no violence outscoring every tragedy, and Season 4 episode 17 runs the experiment that settles it.

For eight rounds nothing in this project ran the equivalent test on crisis. The 60%-death problem was noticed in July, written down, and never touched again.

That is not a cliffhanger. It is a **gap**, and pointing at your own untested assumption is worth more than a resolved one.

It has since been run, and Season 4 episode 18 is the round that runs it. Hold two things until then, because the pair is the point.

Deleting **king** from **marks** turned out to be **inert**. Nothing the project rests on moved. So the obvious lesson is that a dominant word is an alarming number and not a problem.

Deleting death from crisis removes a third of the metric, and the check the project uses to validate that metric **reports no change at all.**

Same instrument, same kind of edit, opposite outcomes. **Work out now what could make those two results compatible**, because the answer is a fact about the metric rather than about either word, and it is the best thing in Season 4.

What would count against this

1. **Crises in literature that arrive with distinctions intact and simply escalate from real, stable differences.** Girard needs the differences to fail first.
2. **The three signs failing to co-occur.** If plague, doubling and civil strife turn out to be statistically unrelated across a large corpus, the grouping is arbitrary. **Season 3 measures the correlations between the buckets and the answer is genuinely interesting.**
3. **A community in crisis that resolves it some other way** and stays resolved. That is episode 5's problem.

Handing off

The crisis has no internal brake. Everyone against everyone does not settle down on its own, and the feedback loop from episode 2 only points one direction.

So how does it ever stop? Episode 5 is Girard's answer, and it is the most famous thing he ever wrote and **the weakest joint in his whole system.**

Questions

1. Is "death" evidence of a crisis of distinctions, or evidence that the text is a tragedy? Say what evidence would tell them apart.

2. Squid Game's crisis is manufactured by organisers who profit from it. Does an external manipulator break Girard's account, or fit inside it?

3. "A rivalry is itself a model." Test it: name a conflict you watched from outside that made you want something you had not wanted before.

4. Name a crisis in a story where distinctions collapse **without** plague, twins or civil war. What does that text use instead, and should it be in the bucket?

Collecting four episodes, because this one is the payoff

Episode 3 ended on the **monstrous double**: two rivals who have become interchangeable, each experiencing the other as a thing wearing his face, and reaching for inhuman language to describe him.

Episode 4 ended on a crisis with **no internal brake**. Everyone against everyone, a feedback loop that only points one way, and no mechanism inside the system for stopping.

This episode does one thing: it takes the monstrous double and gives it to an entire community, pointed at one person.

The character

Zuko's banishment.

A room full of people. One person is marked, and the mark is on his face for the rest of the series. The room's tension resolves onto him, and the room goes back to functioning.

And here is the part to watch. **Nobody in that room afterwards describes it as a mob.** They describe it as **justice**, and they are not lying.

The harder and better anchor: any school you were ever in. The mechanism does not require a monster. It requires a room, a tension, and one person who can be selected without anyone retaliating on their behalf.

The claim, which is the famous one

The crisis of episode 4 has no internal brake. What ends it, on Girard's account, is a **switch**: all against everyone becomes **all against one**.

The community selects a victim. Not for a reason that would survive inspection. **For availability**. The violence that was flying in every direction goes in one direction, is discharged, and stops.

Stop here, because this is the weakest joint in the whole theory

Do not smooth this over on camera.

Everything up to this point has a mechanism you can watch operating. Copied desire produces rivalry. Rivalry produces doubles. Doubles multiplied produce a crisis. Each step follows from the one before and you can see why.

And then: "and then everyone turns on one person."

Why one? Why does all-against-all become all-against-one rather than continuing, or burning itself out, or fracturing into factions that stabilise?

Girard's answer is that **the mob's imitation converges the way everything else in the system converges**. A crowd copying each other's hostility will land on the same target for the same reason a crowd copying each other's desire lands on the same object. **The hostility is mimetic too.**

That is coherent. It uses no new machinery. **It is also the one step in the sequence with no independent evidence behind it.**

A critic who wants to break Girard should attack here, not at the stereotypes. The stereotypes are testable and this project spends eight rounds testing them. **The switch is not testable by anything in this series,** and it is the load-bearing joint between the psychology and the anthropology.

Say that out loud. It costs nothing, and it is what an honest teacher does.

And then the part that makes this a theory about texts at all

This is the step people miss, and without it none of the rest of the series makes sense.

The peace afterwards is real. The community genuinely feels better. The violence has stopped. Whatever was tearing the place apart is no longer tearing it apart.

So now run the community's own reasoning, from inside, with no bad faith anywhere:

- before: chaos
- we removed him
- after: peace

He must have been the cause. Look what happened when he was taken away.

The mechanism produces its own justification, and it produces it after the fact. That is the sentence carrying this episode.

Nobody lied. Nobody conspired. The community observed a real correlation and drew the only inference available to people standing where they were standing.

Why the victim ends up sacred, which sounds strange and follows exactly

He caused the crisis, on their reading. **And he ended it.**

So he is simultaneously the worst thing that ever happened to this community and the source of its order. That is not a contradiction they have to resolve. **It is what a god looks like in the oldest layer of myth:** dangerous, set apart, and the reason things work.

Zuko again, and it is exact. Banished as a disgrace, and the same story makes him the one who restores the balance. **The story does not experience that as odd.**

The device: the mechanism as four states

Draw it once and leave it up. Everything in episodes 6 to 9 is a way of detecting one of these four rows in a text.

	THE COMMUNITY	THE VICTIM
1 crisis	all against all, distinctions gone	not yet chosen
2 selection	needs one, not any one	acquires the marks retrospectively
3 violence	all against one, unanimous	killed or expelled
4 peace	distinctions return	becomes sacred, both curse and cure

Row 4 is why nobody inside can see it. The peace is real, it arrives on schedule, and it is the evidence the community uses to conclude that the victim was guilty. **The mechanism produces its own proof.**

The clinical anchor

A treatment given at the moment a self-limiting illness turns the corner.

The patient recovers. The recovery is real. The timing is real. And the causal story writes itself, and it will be repeated confidently for years, and there is nothing dishonest anywhere in the chain.

That is what makes the mechanism hard to see from inside: the evidence for the wrong explanation is genuine.

Where this becomes countable

The four stereotypes in episodes 6 to 9 are Girard's list of **the traces this mechanism leaves in a text**, and that list is the entire basis of the instrument.

And here is the limit, said in this episode rather than later.

Everything in episodes 1 to 5 is a claim about what happened in **real communities, in prehistory, before writing**. Nothing in this project tests any of it. No instrument can reach a mechanism that operated before there were texts.

What the instrument tests is far narrower: whether the **residue** Girard says the mechanism leaves is detectable in texts, in the pattern he says it should be. **That is a smaller question, and it is the only one a corpus and a computer can ask.**

What would count against this

1. **Crises that resolve without a victim**, routinely, in the historical and ethnographic record. Girard needs the victim to be the normal exit.
2. **Victims selected for properties that genuinely predict the crisis**, rather than for availability. If the selection turns out to be rational, the theory loses its point.
3. **Communities that do not sacralise the victim afterwards**. The double attribution, dangerous and saving, is the theory's fingerprint.

None of the three is tested here. Say it again.

Handing off

Episode 6 stops doing philosophy and starts making a list, because a list is the only thing you can turn into code.

Questions

1. The mechanism requires that the community cannot see it operating. **If it cannot be seen from inside, how did anyone ever describe it?** Girard has an answer and it is episode 13.
-

-
2. Girard says the victim's guilt is produced by the peace. What would a case look like where the victim really was guilty? Does the theory have room for it?
-

-
3. "Selected for availability, not for a reason." **Is that falsifiable?** Write your answer and keep it. Season 3 tests a version of it four separate times.
-

-
4. The clinical anchor: name a real case where a genuine correlation produced a confident wrong explanation that lasted years.
-
-

Collecting episode 5

Episode 5 ended with a mechanism that **operated before writing** and that **nobody inside it could see**. Which leaves an obvious problem: if it is invisible from the inside and prehistoric, how would anyone ever study it?

Girard's answer is that it leaves residue. The people who ran the mechanism went on to tell stories about what happened, and the stories carry marks.

From here the season stops doing philosophy and starts making **a list**, because a list is the only thing you can turn into code.

Source: Girard, *The Scapegoat*, chapter 2.

The frame, and one sentence makes it testable

Girard says a text written **by the persecutors**, who do not know they are persecutors, carries four marks. He calls them the stereotypes of persecution.

And the thing to say slowly: they are not four themes.

A theme is something a text is about. **These are four positions in one event**, seen from different places, by people with different amounts of information.

#	STEREOTYPE	WHOSE VIEW IT IS	ONE LINE
1	crisis	the community's	everything that made us different has stopped working
2	crimes	the accusers'	here is what he did
3	marks	the accusers'	here is why it was him and not someone else
4	violence	nobody's, it is what happens	all of us, on one of him

Four episodes, one each, because each of the four has its own vocabulary, its own dominant word, its own way of going wrong, and its own number that comes back later to do damage. Taking them in pairs hides exactly the thing worth seeing, which is that **they fail differently**.

Stereotype 1, and the part episode 4 did not do

Episode 4 gave you the crisis as a phenomenon. Plague, famine, sterility, twins, doubles, civil strife. A community describing a world in which distinctions have stopped working. Do not re-teach it.

This episode is the other half, and it is the half nobody does. You have a phenomenon. Now turn it into something a machine can count, which means writing down the actual words.

Here is the list, as it was written, before any text existed:

> plague · pestilence · famine · drought · blight · barren · sterile · sickness · > disease · **death** · twin · twins · double · doubles · likeness

Look at how the list is built, because the construction is doing two different jobs at once. Some of those words name **the disaster**. Some of them name **the loss of difference**, which is what the disaster means in the theory. Twins and doubles and likeness are not

calamities at all. They are in the bucket because Girard says undifferentiation is the crisis, and twins are undifferentiation with a face.

So the bucket already contains a theoretical commitment, and it is a good one, and nobody scoring a text will ever see it. **This is what an operationalization is**: a claim about the world, compressed into a list, and then invisible for the rest of the project.

The number, and it is the worst one in the instrument

crisis fires at **2.07 per thousand words**. Middle of the pack.

And it is **60% the single word death**.

Sixty percent. That is the highest domination of any of the four buckets, and it is worth sitting with before you hear the other three, because it sets the standard against which they will look healthy.

Why that number is a problem and not a curiosity

Ask what **death** tells you about a text.

Almost nothing, because it is one of the most common words in narrative literature of any kind. Epics are full of deaths. Tragedies are full of deaths. Genealogies are full of deaths, in the flattest possible sense, because that is what a genealogy is. Hymns mention death. Philosophy mentions death.

So a bucket built to detect **a community losing its distinctions** is, in practice, six-tenths a detector for **somebody having died**, which is a different claim and a much duller one.

The crisis bucket is the one place in the instrument where the theory is loudest and the measurement is weakest. Episode 4 spent ten minutes on the most interesting idea in Girard, and this is what it looks like once it has been made countable.

The character anchor

Agent Smith.

He starts as one agent among several, a distinct thing with a role. Then he copies himself onto everybody, and by the end the street is full of Smiths, and the point is not that Smith is strong. **The point is that difference has stopped existing**, which is the crisis stereotype in one image.

And now the joke the instrument played on itself. **The bucket built to detect undifferentiation lost its own differentiation**. Fifteen words went in, and one of them replicated across the bucket until it was 60% of everything the bucket reports. **plague** and **sterile** and **twins** are still in there, doing almost nothing, the way the last non-Smith is still technically on the street.

The clinical anchor

Fever.

It is a real sign, not noise and not an artifact, and a patient with a fever genuinely has something going on. **And it barely narrows anything**, because it is present in most of

what walks through the door, so the differential you had before you took the temperature is roughly the differential you have after.

Fever is a symptom that is common enough to be almost uninformative, and that is exactly **death** at 60%. **A word can be a correct member of a category and still destroy the category's usefulness by being everywhere.**

What would count against this

1. **death genuinely being the crisis marker in these texts.** A serious objection, and the strongest one available. In a plague narrative the deaths **are** the crisis, so the word is not a contaminant, it is the thing itself. **Nobody has read a sample of death hits in context to find out**, which is a day's work and would settle it.
2. **The bucket working anyway.** Domination is not the same as failure. Delete **death**, re-run everything, and see whether any result moves. **Never done**, for any bucket, in any round.
3. **60% being normal.** If every word-list in every field is dominated by its commonest member, this is a fact about language rather than a defect here. Plausible, and it would make the number less alarming without making the bucket any more useful.

Handing off

That is the community's view of what is happening. **Episode 7 is the accusers' view of who did it**, and it contains the rarest bucket in the instrument and the one that kills the project's first prediction.

Questions

1. Twins and likeness are in a bucket about catastrophe. **Explain why**, then decide whether you would have put them there.

2. The bucket is 60% one word. **Is that a broken bucket or a fact about narrative?** Say what evidence would tell you.

3. Write the crisis word-list you would have written, before seeing the other three buckets. **Keep it.** Episode 9 lets you score yourself.

Collecting episode 6

Episode 6 was the community saying **what is happening to us**. This episode is the accusers saying **what he did**, and where the crisis bucket failed by being too common, this one fails by being too rare.

The distinction that everything later depends on

Say this now, and it gets said again in episode 9, because a later episode is about the day it nearly got broken.

Stereotype 2 is what the victim is ACCUSED of. Stereotype 4 is what the crowd DOES. Different buckets. Confusing them wrecks the instrument.

Hold it. **Season 2 episode 9** is the episode where somebody, reasonably, with entirely good intentions, almost merges them to fix a failing prediction, and the reason it would have been cheating is not statistical.

The pattern inside the accusations

Here is the observation that makes this more than a list of bad things.

The accusation is never a small crime. Nobody is scapegoated for petty theft, or laziness, or being bad at their job. It is always a crime that **erases a distinction the community lives by**, and Girard sorts them into four families.

FAMILY	EXAMPLES	THE DIFFERENCE IT ERASES
violence against the most protected	killing a father, a king, a child	kin against stranger, ruler against ruled
sexual transgression	incest, bestiality	family against outsider, human against animal
religious crime	sacrilege, blasphemy, profanation	sacred against common
contagion crimes	poisoning, sorcery, treason	spreads invisibly, erasing the line between one person and everyone

And now the argument, which is the whole episode

Look at what those four have in common. Not "they are serious." **Look at the shape.**

Every one of them describes **a person who collapsed a distinction.**

And episode 6 told you what the crisis is: **distinctions collapsing.**

So the community is accusing one person of being the crisis.
The victim is charged with **being the thing that is happening to everybody.**

That is the logic in a sentence, and it is why the crime families are not an arbitrary list. They are the crisis, attributed to a person.

And it explains something otherwise strange: why the accusations in these stories are so lurid and so specific. A community that says "he made us all alike" has said nothing

actionable. A community that says "he slept with his mother" has said the same thing in a form you can execute someone for.

That is the step worth slowing down on, because it is where the theory earns its keep. **The crisis is real and it is abstract**, and nobody can be put to death for an abstraction. The accusation is the crisis translated into a charge, and a charge has a defendant, and a defendant can be dealt with in an afternoon.

The lurid detail is not decoration and it is not sadism. It is the conversion step, and a community that could not perform it would be stuck with a catastrophe it had no way to end.

The clinical anchor

A diagnosis of exclusion, arrived at from the wrong end.

A patient is unwell and nothing fits. The picture is diffuse, the tests are equivocal, and there is real pressure in the room to name something, because a name is what lets the next step happen. **A named condition can be treated. An unexplained deterioration cannot be**, and everyone in the corridor knows which of those two the family will accept.

The label that gets attached is often specific out of all proportion to the evidence for it, and the specificity is the point. **It converts a situation into a problem**, and the conversion is what the room actually needed.

The character anchors

Light Yagami is accused, correctly, of exactly this shape. Kira's crime is not murder in the ordinary sense; the show is not interested in a body count. It is that he **dissolves the difference between the judge and the criminal**, and everyone who is frightened of him is frightened of that.

Tom Ripley is the identity version. What disturbs people is not the killing. It is that he can **occupy another man's life and nobody can tell**. He is a crime against distinctions in person.

The number to plant, and where it goes off

crimes turns out to be the **rarest** of the four buckets. **0.95 hits per thousand words**, against violence at 4.76.

Five times rarer.

And put it against episode 6, because the pair is the finding. Crisis is dominated 60% by one word. **Crimes is dominated only 12%**, by **murder**, which makes it the most evenly spread bucket in the instrument and the best built of the four.

The best-constructed bucket is the rarest one. Nothing was done wrong. The vocabulary of accusation is simply not high-frequency vocabulary, and no amount of care in building the list changes how often the words occur.

Plant that and leave it. **It detonates in Season 3 episode 2**, where one line of arithmetic explains why the project's first prediction failed, and the arithmetic has nothing to do with Girard at all.

And the reason it is rare, which is a finding in its own right

Worth an extra minute, because it is a genuine discovery about **language** rather than about theory.

Narrative texts **do not say "he committed parricide."** They say **"he slew his father."**

The words **parricide**, **patricide** and **regicide** fire **zero times in roughly two hundred thousand words** of Greek and Roman literature.

The theory names the crime with a label. The texts describe it with a verb.

That gap is not a technicality. It is where the first version of the instrument died, and repairing it is most of Season 2 episode 9.

What would count against this

1. **Accusations in persecution texts that are ordinary crimes.** If victims were routinely charged with theft, cowardice or incompetence rather than difference-erasing crimes, the four families are a pattern imposed rather than found.
2. **The four families appearing at the same rate in texts with no persecution in them.** That is checkable and Season 3 checks a version of it.
3. **Communities that accuse the victim of nothing at all** and simply expel him. Girard needs the accusation to do work.

A word about the play that is going to come up in every season, because it is named here for the first time and it carries more weight than any other text in this project.

The ***Bacchae*** is a Greek tragedy by **Euripides**, written around 405 BC. The god Dionysus arrives in the city of Thebes and the king, **Pentheus**, refuses to recognise him and has him arrested. Dionysus drives the women of Thebes into a frenzy out on the mountain, Pentheus goes to spy on them, and they tear him apart with their hands. **The woman who leads the killing is Agave, his own mother**, and she carries his head back into the city believing it is a lion's.

That tearing-apart has a Greek name, **sparagmos**, and it is the technical term for the ritual dismemberment of a living victim by a crowd. **Keep the word. It returns in Season 3**, where the instrument tries to locate that exact passage.

Now keep number 3 in mind. **In Girard's own best example, the mob does not believe it is executing a criminal.** It believes it is killing a lion. **Episode 15 reads the play in full**, and the accusation stereotype is the weakest of the four in it.

Why Girard leans on it so hard: a mother killing her son, in public, unanimously, while believing she is doing something else entirely. **All four stereotypes in one scene**, which is why it becomes the exemplar the whole project is repeatedly tested against, and why it failing four pre-registered tests later matters so much.

Hanging off

The accusers have said what he did. **Episode 8 is the accusers saying why it was him**, and it contains the single most counter-intuitive claim in the theory and the one that later breaks the instrument.

Questions

1. Girard's four crime families all erase a distinction. Is that a **discovery** about how accusations work, or a **definition** built so they fit?

2. Take a real accusation from the last five years, one you followed closely. Which family does it fall into, and does the fit feel forced?

3. "The victim is charged with being the thing that is happening to everybody." Test it against a case you know well.

4. The best-built bucket is the rarest. **Is there anything you could have done about that?** Answer before Season 3 episode 2.

Collecting episode 7

Episode 7 ended with the accusers saying **what he did**. This episode is the accusers saying **why it was him**, and it answers the obvious question nobody asks.

Why him

If the mechanism really is a community discharging its own tension, and the victim is not actually the cause, the choice looks arbitrary. **But it is not random either**, and Girard's answer is precise.

Victims are chosen for **a sign that puts them slightly outside the group, without giving them the power to retaliate**.

Both halves do work. **Outside enough** that turning on them does not feel like turning on ourselves. **Weak enough** that nobody comes for revenge afterwards, because revenge would restart the crisis and ending the crisis was the whole point.

Notice that this is a two-condition test, which is unusual in Girard and worth flagging as a gift. Most of the theory is stated in a form that accommodates whatever you find. **This one can be run on a candidate and fail**, and the next section runs it.

Two directions, and the second is the one people miss

Too low. The stranger, the foreigner, the cripple, the lame, the blind, the deformed, the beggar, the orphan. Everyone expects this list.

Too high. The king. The queen. The tyrant.

Why "too high" works, because the episode has to earn this

Just asserting that the king is a victim mark is not enough. **Run the two criteria on him.**

Is he outside the group? Completely. A king has no peers by definition. He is the one person in the society who does not have an equal, and every ritual around him exists to say so.

Can he retaliate? This is the counter-intuitive half. He looks like the most powerful person there. But **he has no faction of his own kind**, because there is no other king. When a community turns on him, **nobody is obliged to avenge him**, because he stands in no relation of equals to anybody.

A powerful man with peers is dangerous to attack. **A powerful man with no peers is the safest target in the room**, and this is precisely inverted from how it looks.

And there is a further argument Girard makes, which is worth having because it explains why kingship keeps showing up in these stories at all: in many traditions the king is a **victim whose execution has been deferred**. The rituals that set him apart, the taboos, the special food, the special clothing, the periodic humiliations, look like the treatment of a sacred victim postponed.

Mark that as tier K. The comparative material on sacred kingship is real and this series has not gone and checked the sources. **Say so rather than implying you have.**

The device: the two criteria, run as a grid

Put the two questions on one axis and the candidates on the other, and the "too high" category stops being a paradox.

CANDIDATE	OUTSIDE THE GROUP?	ABLE TO RETALIATE?	A VICTIM MARK?
an ordinary member	no	yes	no
the stranger, the cripple, the beggar	yes	no	yes
a powerful man with peers	no	yes	no
the king	yes , he has no equals	no , no faction of his own kind	yes

Read the third and fourth rows together. They are both powerful. Only one of them is a victim mark, and the difference is not power. **It is whether anybody is obliged to avenge him.**

The character anchors

Too low: Zuko's scar. Visible, permanent, on the face, and given to him by his own father inside his own family.

Too high: Macbeth. A king who becomes the thing the kingdom must expel to be well again, and the play describes the country as **sick** and the cure as removing him.

And the modern one, which lands hardest: BoJack. Marked by being famous, which is the too-high position exactly. The story is about a public turning on him with grievances that are **completely real** and a process that is **completely mechanical**, at the same time, and it refuses to let you pick one reading.

That is the most useful thing about BoJack here. **The mechanism does not require the victim to be innocent.** It only requires that the turning is doing something for the people turning.

The number, and it is the one that comes back hardest

marks fires at **2.90 per thousand words**, and it is **44% the single word king**.

Put it in the sequence you now have. Crisis 60% **death**. Crimes 12% **murder**. Marks 44% **king**. **The bucket carrying Girard's most distinctive claim is the second most dominated**, and dominated by a word that is not a description of a person at all. It is a job title.

So an instrument built to detect victim-marking will in practice very largely detect **whether a text is about royalty**. And the highest **marks** score in the whole corpus belongs to Sophocles' *Oedipus the King*, in which the title character is addressed as king on nearly every page.

Do not resolve this on camera

Two readings, both live, both coming out of the same number.

The objection. The bucket is broken. It picks up a genre signal, not a victim mark. Any text set in a palace scores high and it means nothing.

Girard's reading. The king **is** a marked victim, for the reasons three paragraphs up, and a text full of kings really is full of potential victims.

Say that this episode **cannot settle it**. What settles it is an experiment in **Season 4** where the word is simply deleted and everything re-run, and **the answer is not the one this episode makes you expect**.

The clinical anchor

The patient nobody is calling about.

No family in the corridor, no relative who works in health, no one who knows which words to use. **Nothing has been decided against them.** No individual decision on that ward is unfair.

And they are, quietly, the one whose discharge gets pushed, whose complaint gets recorded as agitation, whose plan changes without a conversation. **Slightly outside, and nobody to answer to afterwards**, which is Girard's two conditions in a corridor rather than a myth.

What would count against this

1. **Victims in these stories who are ordinary, unmarked members of the community**, chosen with no distinguishing feature at all. The marks stereotype needs marks.
2. **The "too high" category being an artifact.** If deleting **king** destroys the instrument's results, the category was carrying the bucket rather than describing the world. **Season 4 episode 17 runs exactly this test.**
3. **The two-condition test never actually being run on anything else.** It was run on the king, in this episode, by Girard. **Nobody has taken a list of attested victims and checked what proportion satisfies both conditions**, which is the version of this that would be evidence rather than illustration.

Handing off

The accusers have said what he did and why it was him. **Episode 9 is the crowd doing something about it**, and it is where a word-list stops being about the victim and starts being about everybody else.

Questions

1. Is "king" a victim mark or a genre signal? **State what evidence would settle it**, in advance, before you are shown the experiment.
-
-

2. The "no peers means no avengers" argument. Test it: name a powerful figure whose fall met no organised resistance from anyone like them.

3. Three buckets, three domination figures: 60%, 12%, 44%. **Predict the fourth** before episode 9 tells you, and say why.

Collecting episode 8

Three stereotypes down, and all three have been about **one person**: what is happening to the community, what he is accused of, why he was chosen.

This one is about everybody else.

And collect the distinction from episode 7, because this is the bucket it protects against: **stereotype 2 is what the victim is accused of. Stereotype 4 is what the crowd does.** Season 2 episode 9 is the day that nearly got broken.

Three components, and the third is the series

The crowd itself. Crowd, mob, throng, multitude, rabble.

What it does. Stones, expels, banishes, drives out, hunts, tears apart.

Its unanimity. With one voice. One accord. As one man. The whole city.

And the third component is the rest of the series

The unanimity is not a detail. It is the load-bearing part, and here is why that is a design decision worth explaining on camera.

When you look at the word-list in Season 2, you will find phrases in the **violence** bucket that are not violence words at all: **with one voice, one accord, as one man, the whole city.**

Those are unanimity words, and they are in the violence bucket because for Girard the unanimity is what makes the violence work. Violence without unanimity is just a fight. Violence with unanimity is a mechanism.

And Girard's entire distinction between myth and Gospel, the claim that Seasons 3 and 4 spend eleven episodes failing to measure, is **only about whether that unanimity holds.** Not whether there is violence. Not whether the victim is innocent. **Whether anybody breaks ranks.**

Which means this bucket is doing two jobs under one name, and **it will be split apart in Season 3** into a fifth bucket built entirely out of the crowd coming apart. Everything the project eventually finds, and it is not much, lives in that split.

And be clear about what kind of mistake the merger is, because it is not a mislabelling. **The two things have completely different frequencies.** Violence words are everywhere in Greek literature; unanimity phrases are rare and turn up only when a text is describing a group acting as one. Put a rare, decisive signal into the same bucket as a common, uninformative one and **the total is the common one**, to within a rounding error, forever.

Nobody chose that. It follows from addition, and it was locked in the day somebody decided which bucket **with one voice** belonged to.

The character anchor

"I am Spartacus."

Everybody knows the scene and almost nobody notices what it is. A crowd is ordered to identify one man. **The mechanism requires exactly one thing from them, which is that they point**, and instead every man claims to be him.

Nothing about that scene is a rescue. It does not save Spartacus and the men know it will not. **What it destroys is the unanimity**, and the reason it is one of the most famous moments in cinema is that an audience feels, without being told, that something enormous has been broken.

Hold that scene for four seasons. It is the negative image of everything this instrument is built to find, and the whole of Season 3's dissent lexicon is an attempt to detect it in Greek.

The clinical anchor

Quorum sensing.

Bacteria that individually do nothing at all. Each one releases a signal molecule, each one measures how much of that signal is around it, and **below a threshold every single cell stays inert**. Cross the threshold and they all switch on together, and the population starts behaving as one organism.

The individual bacterium has not changed. **What changed is that it detected agreement**, and agreement is the trigger rather than the accompaniment.

That is Girard's claim about crowds, in a system with no minds in it: the destructive behaviour is not the sum of individual intentions, **it is switched on by unanimity itself**.

The four numbers to have cold

Four episodes, four buckets. **Here is the whole instrument on one slide**, and you have already met three of the rows.

BUCKET	RATE PER 1000	DOMINATED BY	THAT WORD'S SHARE
violence	4.76	blood	21%
marks	2.90	king	44%
crisis	2.07	death	60%
crimes	0.95	murder	12%

Violence is the commonest bucket and the second least dominated. Which makes it, on the two crude measures available, the healthiest of the four: plenty of hits, no single word running away with it.

And that is the trap. **The healthiest bucket measures the thing Girard cares least about.** He is not claiming that persecution texts are violent. Everything in Greek literature is violent. **He is claiming something about the unanimity**, and the unanimity is a handful of phrases hiding inside the one bucket nobody would think to look in.

The translation problem, planted here because it lands in Season 3

The unanimity signal is phrases, and phrases are the first thing a translator changes.

With one voice, one accord, as one man, the whole city. Every one of those is an idiom, and a translator rendering the same Greek as "everyone shouted" has

preserved the meaning perfectly and **destroyed the measurement completely**.

Compare that with the rest of the instrument. **Blood, king, death, murder** are single common nouns, and any competent translator will use them because there is nothing else to use. **The buckets built out of ordinary words are robust to translation. The one carrying Girard's actual claim is not.**

So the most theoretically important signal in the instrument is also the most fragile one, and **it is fragile in a way no amount of statistics can repair**, because the information was lost before the corpus existed.

Season 3 episode 5 measures this, once, on one paired play, and finds two translators differing by 17.2% on total rate. Nobody has ever measured it on the unanimity phrases specifically, which is where it would bite hardest.

What would count against this

1. **Unanimity language turning out to be equally common in texts with no collective violence in them.** Then it is a rhetorical register, not a fingerprint. **Season 3 tests exactly this and the answer is not clean.**
2. **The unanimity phrases being too rare to measure.** They are phrases rather than words, in a corpus of translations, and a translator who writes "everyone shouted" instead of "with one voice" has erased the signal without changing the meaning. **This is the objection the project takes least seriously and it may be the strongest.**
3. **Putting unanimity in the violence bucket being simply wrong.** It merges a frequent, uninformative thing with a rare, decisive one, and the rare one disappears into the total. **Season 3 splits them out and everything the project finds comes from the split**, which is an argument that they should never have been together.

Handing off

Four stereotypes, four episodes, four numbers. **Episode 10 is short and it is the most important one in the season**, because it is about the single word that turns this list into a theory: **together**.

Questions

1. Girard needs unanimity. **What is the smallest crack that breaks it?** One dissenting voice? Two? A dissenter nobody listens to?

2. Why put unanimity words in the violence bucket rather than giving them their own? Argue both ways, then note that Season 3 gives them their own.

3. Go back to the crisis list you wrote in episode 6. **Score it against the real one.** What did you include that a corpus would drown, and what did you miss?

4. Four buckets, dominated 60%, 12%, 44%, 21%. **Which of the four would you trust most, and does trust track domination?**

Episode 7 finished the list. **This episode is about one word in it: together.**

It introduces no new content and it is the most important episode in the season.

Two reasons. It is the difference between a theory and a vocabulary. And it tells you **exactly what Seasons 3 and 4 are going to fail at.**

Collecting episodes 6 to 9

Four episodes, four stereotypes, four numbers. Crisis at 2.07 per thousand and 60% one word. Crimes at 0.95, the rarest and the best built. Marks at 2.90 and 44% **king**. Violence at 4.76, the commonest, with the unanimity phrases hidden inside it.

That is a list. This episode is about the one word that turns a list into a theory, and it introduces no new content at all.

Take the four apart and they are worth nothing

Say this plainly, before a critic says it for you.

Violent stories contain violence. Not a finding. A tautology.

Stories about kings contain the word king. Also not a finding.

Tragedies contain death. Tragedies are about people dying.

Myths contain accusations. Myths are about people being accused.

Any one of the four, found alone, in a text of the relevant genre, proves **nothing at all**. You could build a word-list for almost any theory and find it in Greek literature, because Greek literature is enormous and about extreme things.

The device: the ladder, and only one rung holds weight

Draw three rungs and write the number on each one.

LEVEL	THE CLAIM	WHAT THE CORPUS SAYS	WORTH TESTING?
1	each vocabulary appears in these texts	trivially true	no
2	all four appear in the same text	true in 90% of 72 texts	almost worthless
3	all four converge on one passage	this is the whole project	yes

Three levels of claim, and only one of them is worth testing

This is the spine of the episode. **Draw it as a ladder.**

Level 1. Each vocabulary appears in these texts. Trivially true. Nobody needs an instrument.

Level 2. All four appear in the same text. This sounds much stronger. **It is almost as trivial, and here is the number that proves it.**

When the instrument is finally built and run on 72 Greek and Roman texts, the score for the weakest of the four buckets is **above zero in 90% of them.**

All four stereotypes are present in nine out of ten texts in the corpus. Including the ones that are not about persecution at all. **Level 2 is nearly worthless as evidence**, and knowing that now is what stops you being impressed by it later.

Level 3. All four converge on the same passage, more than chance would put them there.

That is the claim, and it is what "four faces of one event" means if it means anything. One process, one place, one moment: the crisis, the accusation, the marks, the killing.

The difference between level 2 and level 3 is the difference between a word list and a theory. A word list says these terms show up in these books. A theory says they show up in the same place, because one thing caused all four.

And here is what the season is really telling you

The project measured level 3 **four separate times, with four different instruments, and failed every time.**

Not because the Gospels came out wrong. Not because the corpus was bad. **Because the convergence was not there to find, or the instruments could not see it, and after four attempts nobody can say which.**

Say that here. **It is not a spoiler, it is the reason to keep watching**, and it is more honest than pretending the series has a triumphant ending.

The clinical anchor, and it is not a metaphor

A raised white cell count means nothing on its own. Fifty causes.

A fever means nothing on its own. A hundred causes.

A raised lactate means nothing on its own.

Sepsis is the claim that they arrive together, because one process produces all of them. That is what a syndrome is. It is a stronger claim than a symptom and correspondingly harder to demonstrate.

And you already know the objections to a syndrome, which is why this anchor is worth the time:

- *your three findings are common in sick patients generally*
- *you have defined a cluster that would appear by chance in any intensive care unit*
- *your criteria were built by looking at patients who already had the diagnosis*

Every one of those has an exact counterpart in this series. The first is level 2 above. The second is what a null test is for, and it is Season 3 episode 11. The third is why the word-list had to be written before the corpus existed, which is Season 2 episode 2.

The character anchor

A relay team.

Nobody thinks the fastest individual leg tells you about the team. The claim "this team is good" is a claim about the **weakest** leg, because the baton has to go all the way round.

That is exactly the difference between **adding four numbers** and **taking the smallest of them**, and it is the choice Season 2 episode 12 makes and the choice Season 3 episode 2 destroys.

One number to plant, and it is the strangest in the season

If the four stereotypes are four faces of one event, they should **rise and fall together** across texts. A text high on one should tend to be high on the others.

Season 3 measures the correlations between the four buckets across 76 texts.

They come out between **0.13 and 0.38**. Crisis against marks is **0.13**, which is close to no relationship at all.

Work out before Season 3 whether that helps Girard or hurts him, because it genuinely cuts both ways and the episode will not tell you.

Low correlation means the four are **not redundant**. They are genuinely four different measurements rather than four names for one thing, which is what the theory needs. **And** it means they do not co-occur strongly, which is what the theory predicts they should.

What would count against this

1. **Level 3 holding for texts that are obviously not persecution texts.** Then convergence is a property of narrative, not of the mechanism.
2. **The four buckets turning out to be nearly perfectly correlated.** Then they are one measurement with four names and the conjunction claim is empty.
3. **Level 3 failing everywhere.** Which is what happens, four times, and the honest question then becomes whether the theory is wrong or the instrument is blind. **Season 3 episode 19 leaves that open and so should you.**

Handing off

The list is finished and its testable shape is fixed, and this episode has told you which rung of the ladder is worth testing.

Episode 11 asks whether Girard agrees, and the answer is on a page that took eight rounds and a citation check to open. **Then episodes 12 and 13 are what he does with the list:** the claim about myth, and the claim about the Gospels, which are the two most contested things he ever wrote and the two that Seasons 3 and 4 attack directly.

Questions

1. All four present in 90% of texts. **Write down, now, what you would require instead** before you would call a convergence real.

2. If level 3 fails everywhere, is Girard wrong or is the instrument blind? **Answer now.** You will want it in Season 3 episode 19, and you will want to see whether you

changed your mind.

-
-
3. The four buckets correlate at 0.13 to 0.38. Does that help the theory or hurt it? Argue both, then pick.

-
-
4. Sepsis has an agreed definition and a denominator. **What would a denominator be for persecution texts?** What are you dividing by?
-
-

This episode exists because somebody finally opened the books. Every page number quoted in this series came out of the project's own files and had never been checked against a copy. When they were checked, three of four needed a correction, and one of them turned out to be about the argument rather than the page.

Collecting episode 10

Episode 10 built a ladder. Level 1, each vocabulary appears. Level 2, all four appear in the same text, which is nearly worthless because **all four fire in 90% of 72 Greek and Roman texts**. Level 3, all four converge on one passage, more than chance would put them there.

And it said level 3 is the claim. This episode asks whether Girard says that, and the answer is on a page nobody in eight rounds had read.

And now the thing that was found by opening the book

This is tier V. Go and check it, the passage is four pages into chapter 3 of The Scapegoat.

Girard states his own decision rule for identifying a persecution text, and it is worth reading in full because nobody in this project had read it until the citations were verified:

"Each time an oral or written testament mentions an act of violence that is directly or indirectly collective we question whether it includes the description of a social and cultural crisis... The juxtaposition of more than one stereotype within a single document indicates persecution. **Not all the stereotypes must be present: three are enough and often even two.**"

Read the last sentence again and put it on the ladder.

That is a **level 2** rule. Presence in a document. And it is not even the strict version of level 2, because it does not ask for four. **It asks for two.**

Girard's own procedure sits on the rung this episode has just shown is nearly worthless, and it sits one rung lower than the version that was measured.

Now apply the project's own number to it. All four buckets fire in **90% of 72 Greek and Roman texts**, including texts with no persecution in them anywhere. If all four are present in nine texts out of ten, then **"three are enough and often even two" classifies almost the whole of Greek literature as a persecution document.**

That is not an objection somebody invented. It is Girard's stated rule meeting this project's measurement, and the measurement was made without anybody noticing it bore on the rule.

The device: put the ladder next to the source

Same three rungs, one extra column, and the column is what the citation check bought.

LEVEL	WHAT IT ASKS	WHO REQUIRES IT
1	the vocabulary appears	nobody
2	two or three of four, anywhere in the document	<i>*Girard, Scapegoat ch. 3*</i>
2 strict	all four, anywhere in the document	true in 90% of texts
3	all four on one passage	this project, and nobody else

Read the second and fourth rows. They are two rungs apart, and the project spent eight rounds on the top one believing it was on Girard's.

What follows, and be careful, because two things do not follow

It does not follow that Girard is wrong, because a rule of thumb for reading a medieval chronicle is not the same as a claim about what the mechanism produces. He may well hold that the event generates all four and that a surviving text preserves only some. **Say that out loud, because it is the strongest defence and it is probably correct.**

And it does not follow that this project was wasting its time. The opposite.

Level 3 is this project's invention. Girard did not ask for co-location on a passage. **The instrument has been testing something harder than its source requires,** for eight rounds, and failing at it.

Which reframes every failure ahead of you.

At the end of Season 3 the tempting sentence is "Girard's claim did not show up." **The honest one is longer and says two things.** The strengthened version of his claim did not show up. **And the version he actually stated is refuted by this project's own 90% figure, in the other direction.**

Hold both. **Neither is comfortable and both are checkable.**

The move that settles it, and it takes one sentence

Here is the question that makes the whole thing tractable, and it is the question to ask of any detection rule anybody ever hands you.

Run it against the case it is supposed to distinguish.

Girard's rule says two or three stereotypes in a document indicate persecution. So run it on **the Passion**, which is the standard name for the last part of the gospel story: the arrest of Jesus, his trial before the Jewish authorities and then Pilate, the crowd calling for his execution, and the crucifixion. From the Latin for suffering, and nothing to do with the modern sense of the word.

That episode is the one text Girard's whole theory has to treat differently, so it is the right thing to point a persecution detector at.

Crisis: a city under occupation, a festival crowd, an authority in conflict with a popular teacher. **Crimes:** blasphemy, which is Girard's third crime family exactly. **Marks:** a provincial and a carpenter's son who is simultaneously a claimed king, both directions at once. **Violence:** a crowd, calling out together, and a public execution.

Four of four. Emphatically. Episode 12 works through it properly, and it is not a grudging pass.

So the rule fires on the Gospels **as hard as it fires on anything**, and by its own terms it must, because Girard says the Gospels describe the same event. **A rule that classifies both sides of your distinction as positive is not a distinction.**

And Girard knows this. That is the part that turns a gotcha into a finding. He never claims the four stereotypes separate myth from Gospel. He puts the whole difference somewhere else, in one sentence about a dissenting voice, and this series reads that sentence in episode 12.

The four stereotypes were never the discriminating instrument. They are the detector. They tell you a persecution is being described. They cannot tell you who is describing it or whether the describer knows what he is doing.

So the finding is not that Girard contradicts himself. **It is that the first three rounds built an ever better detector and tested it as though it were a discriminator.**

The theory says it cannot be one. **And the sentence saying so was on the shelf the whole time.**

Round 4 is the round that finally builds the discriminator. Everything before it was sharpening the wrong tool, and the person sharpening it could have known that from chapter 3 of *The Scapegoat* and page 3 of *I See Satan*.

The character anchor

A recipe you have cooked from memory for years.

You know it. You have made it forty times, you have taught it to somebody else, and you could write it out on request. **Then you find the card**, and it says 180 degrees where you have always used 200, and it does not mention the step you have always thought was the whole trick.

The dish you have been making is not bad. It may genuinely be better. **But it is yours**, and you have spent years attributing it to somebody else, sincerely, without ever once putting the card next to the pan.

That is what happened here, and notice the specific thing that made it possible: **the recipe was quoted from memory of a summary**, and everybody in the chain was quoting the same summary.

The clinical anchor

Citing a guideline you have never opened.

Everybody has done it. You know what the guideline says because you learned it from a senior, who learned it from a talk, which was based on the guideline. **The chain is usually accurate and it is never checkable at any single link**, and the gap between "what the guideline says" and "what everybody knows it says" widens by one small step per retelling.

The uncomfortable part is that this is normally harmless. **It stops being harmless the moment you build an instrument out of it**, because an instrument does not know it is repeating a summary and will happily produce four significant figures on top of one.

What would count against this

1. **The chapter 3 sentence being a rule of thumb rather than a claim.** Argued above and it is probably right. **The counter is that this project's task is precisely the reader's task in that sentence**, which is deciding from a document whether persecution is being described.
2. **Girard saying the opposite somewhere else.** Very likely, across a fifty-year body of work, and **nobody has looked**. One verified sentence is one verified sentence. **This episode is not entitled to say "Girard's position is" on the strength of a single passage**, and neither is the objection it raises.
3. **The 90% figure being an artifact.** It comes from this project's lexicon, and Season 1 episode 8 showed `marks` is 44% the word `king`. **If the buckets fire on genre rather than on persecution, then 90% is a fact about the instrument** and cannot be used against Girard's rule.

Objection 2 is the honest ceiling on this episode. It found one sentence. Finding one sentence is not scholarship, it is the first ten minutes of scholarship, and the series should say so while reporting it.

Handing off

The detector and the discriminator have come apart, and Girard puts the discriminator in one sentence about a voice.

Episode 12 is where myth gets read as the crowd's own account of itself, which is the thing that sentence is about.

Questions

1. **Run Girard's rule on a text you know well.** Two stereotypes out of four. Does it fire? Does that tell you anything?

2. This episode rests on **one** verified sentence. **What would you need to read before saying "Girard's position is"?** Be specific about how much.

3. The project built a harder test than its source required, and failed it. **Is that a better or worse outcome than passing the easy one?**

4. Name a claim in your own field that **everybody cites and nobody has opened**. Then go and open it.

Collecting episode 5, and the whole episode falls out of it

Episode 5 established two things that sit uncomfortably together.

One: the mechanism is invisible from inside it. It only works because the community cannot see what it is doing.

Two: the community afterwards tells stories about what happened.

So a myth is what that invisibility looks like written down.

That is the organizing sentence of this episode. Not "myths are lies." Not "myths are primitive." **Myth is an accurate report by people who could not see the one thing that mattered.**

The character

The Usual Suspects.

The story you are told for two hours is coherent, detailed, internally consistent, and **assembled by the person with the most to gain from you believing it.** It is only visible as a construction in the last ninety seconds, when you see where the details came from.

That is the shape of the claim, and the reason the film works is the reason the claim is hard to test: **from inside the telling, a constructed account and a true one look identical.**

Second anchor: the Death Note ending, from the point of view of ordinary people. Somebody dangerous is gone. Order returns. The account that circulates afterwards is not a lie anyone told. **It is the only account available to people who were not in the room.**

The teaching device: run the causation both ways

This is the thing to put on screen, because it converts the claim from a mood into something you can apply to any story in ten seconds.

What the myth says happened:

he committed the crime -> so we expelled him -> so the plague lifted

What Girard says happened:

the crisis -> we needed somebody -> we expelled him -> the crisis ended
 |
 so he must have caused it <----+

Same events. Same order in time. Opposite direction of causation.

And notice the crucial detail: **the accusation arrives last** in Girard's version, even though it appears first in the telling. The community is not lying about the sequence. It is **explaining a real correlation with the only explanation available to it.**

That is the whole of Girard's reading of myth in one diagram, and you can hand the audience the diagram and let them run it on any story they like.

What that predicts about the shape of myths

A claim about what a text **omits** is a claim you can go and check.

WHAT THE MYTH CONTAINS	WHAT IT LEAVES OUT
the crisis, in vivid detail	that the crisis was ordinary rivalry, spreading
the crime, as established fact	any doubt at all about whether he did it
the marks, as the explanation	that the marks were selected afterwards
the violence, as necessary	that the violence was arbitrary
the victim becoming a god	that the community killed him

And the omission Girard cares most about: nobody in a myth ever suggests the victim might be innocent.

The universal negative, which is the sharpest thing he ever wrote

I See Satan Fall Like Lightning, page 3. **Read it aloud twice.**

"not merely the innocence of the victims versus their guilt, but the fact that, in mythology, **no one ever questions this guilt**. In the Gospels, the revealing account of scapegoating emanates not from the unanimous crowd but from a dissenting few. Initially, Jesus' disciples almost surrender to the mimetic power of the many, but on the third day, thanks to the Resurrection, they secede from the deluded mob and proclaim the innocence of their Lord. **In mythology no dissenting voice is ever heard.**"

Now point at the load-bearing half, because it is routinely misread and the misreading wasted four rounds of this project.

The differentia is NOT "the victims are innocent." Girard rules that out himself, **in the same sentence**: *not merely the innocence of the victims versus their guilt*.

The differentia is "no one ever questions."

It is a claim about **the crowd's verdict**, not about **the victim's character**. Those are two different things and everything in Seasons 3 and 4 turns on the difference.

Why this shape is a gift to anyone trying to test it

A **universal negative** is the most falsifiable shape a claim can take. *This never happens, anywhere, in any of them.* **One genuine counterexample kills it.**

Compare that with almost everything else in Girard, which is a claim about tendencies and readings and cannot be cornered. **This one has an edge you can walk up to.**

That is why Season 3 builds an entire instrument aimed at this single sentence, and why the failure of that instrument is worth four episodes.

The number to plant, and it is the best self-catch in the project

When the project finally built a word-list for that sentence, the list split into two halves.

One half about the victim being innocent: innocent, guiltless, no fault, falsely accused, done nothing.

One half about the crowd being divided: division, some said, others said, not all, spare him.

Across four rounds of testing, the innocence half carried nothing at all and the division half carried everything.

And Girard's own sentence, quoted above, says **innocence is not the differentia**. The instrument was built mostly out of innocence vocabulary anyway.

That detonates in Season 7 episode 4, and it is the strongest self-catch in the whole project: **the word-list contradicted the sentence it was built from, and nobody noticed for four rounds.**

The clinical anchor

The incident report written by the team involved.

It is coherent. It is complete. Every fact in it is true, the timeline is right, and it explains how the outcome followed from the circumstances. **It is also written by the people whose account it exonerates**, and it is the document that enters the record.

Nobody lied. **The account is simply told from the only position available to the people telling it**, which is the position that cannot see itself acting.

What would count against this

1. **A myth containing a sustained dissenting voice.** One is enough. The claim is universal.
2. **Myths that describe the violence as arbitrary**, in their own voice, without a later author's irony. Girard needs the account to be from inside.
3. **The causal reversal failing to fit.** If myths routinely establish the crime independently of the crisis, with evidence, the diagram is wrong.

Number 1 is the one Season 3 goes after, and **what happens is stranger than either passing or failing.**

Handing off

Episode 10 is the other half of the claim, and it is the one that made Girard famous and got him disliked in equal measure: **what the Gospels do differently.**

Questions

1. **Run the two-diagram device on a story you know.** Does the reversal fit? What resists it?
-

2. "No dissenting voice is ever heard." **Describe how you would go looking for one,** before you are shown how it was actually done.

3. If a myth did contain a dissenting voice, would that kill the theory or trim it? **Does Girard get to say "then it is not really a myth"?**

4. Girard says innocence is not the differentia, and the instrument was built out of innocence anyway. **Why do you think that happened?** Answer honestly, because the answer is not stupidity.

Collecting episode 12, and reusing its diagram

Episode 9 gave you two versions of the same events.

What the myth says:

```
he committed the crime -> so we expelled him -> so the plague lifted
```

What Girard reconstructs underneath it:

```
the crisis -> we needed somebody -> we expelled him -> the crisis
ended
                                     |
                                   so he must have caused it <----+
```

The second one is a **reconstruction**. Girard has to argue for it, because no myth says it.

Girard's claim about the Gospels is that they narrate the second diagram directly.
Not as a reconstruction. As the story.

That is the entire episode, and everything else is consequence.

The claim, and it is smaller and stranger than people expect

Girard is **not** saying the Gospels describe a different kind of killing.

He is saying they describe **the same kind of killing**. Same mechanism, same crowd, same arbitrary selection, same manufactured guilt.

What differs is where the camera stands. They narrate it from **the position the myth has to suppress**: the victim's, and the position of the few who do not join in.

I See Satan Fall Like Lightning, page 122:

"it is a rebellious minority, a small group of dissidents that separates from the collective violence of the crowd and **destroys its unanimity**. This minority group is the community of the first witnesses to the Resurrection, that is, the apostles and those who gather around them. **This dissident minority has no equivalent in the myths.**"

The character anchor, and it is the same one

The Usual Suspects again, deliberately, from episode 12, with the last ninety seconds moved to the front.

Same events. Same participants. Same crime. But the telling begins from the knowledge that the crowd's account is a construction, and **once you have that, the entire story reads differently without a single fact changing.**

That is the structural claim, and it is worth making the audience feel it before any theology arrives:

The difference between myth and Gospel, on this account, is not what happened. It is who is holding the camera.

The structural consequence, and it is the thing most people get backwards

If Girard is right, the Gospels should score HIGH on all four stereotypes. Not low.

Run the list from episodes 6 to 9 against the Passion and check:

STEREOTYPE	PRESENT IN THE PASSION?
crisis	a city under occupation, a festival crowd, a religious authority in conflict with a popular teacher
crimes	blasphemy , which is Girard's third crime family exactly
marks	a provincial, a carpenter's son, and simultaneously a claimed king . Both directions from episode 8
violence	a crowd, calling out together, and a public execution

All four. Emphatically.

So the four-bucket instrument built in Season 2 can never tell a Gospel from a myth, and it was never going to. That is the design, not a defect, and the project wrote it down in July before it became inconvenient.

Say that on camera, because it is the kind of limitation people usually discover late and then present as a nuance.

So where is the difference

Girard says exactly where, and it is the one place: **the unanimity breaks**.

Somebody says he has done nothing. Somebody washes his hands. Somebody follows at a distance. The crowd is reported as **divided** rather than as one voice.

And in myth, on Girard's account, **that never happens anywhere**.

Which is why the discriminating instrument, when it is finally built in Season 3, is not about violence at all. It is a word-list for **crowds coming apart**.

The ordinal series, and it is the most tested claim in the project

Girard treats tragedy as **partway** toward revelation. Tragedy knows something is wrong. It does not know what.

So the prediction is not a binary. **It is an ordering**:

myth < tragedy < Gospel in dissent, in broken unanimity

Plant this and do not explain it further. It detonates in Season 3 episode 18.

This series is the **single most tested claim in the entire project**. It was attacked **four times with four different instruments** and survived **none** of them.

Notice why an ordering is a better thing to predict than a difference. **A binary claim has one way to be right and one way to be wrong**. An ordering of three tiers has six possible arrangements and Girard is committed to exactly one of them, so five of the six outcomes are losses. The theory is being made to take on more risk than it has to, deliberately, and that is the whole point of the exercise.

And the reason it failed is not the reason anyone expected. **It did not fail because the Gospels came out low.** It failed because **tragedy and myth turned out to be indistinguishable from each other**, which nobody predicted and nobody has explained.

That detonates in Season 3 episode 18, where a round's own sensitivity analysis shows the **middle of the series does not exist**.

The objection you must raise yourself, in this episode

There is an obvious one and it should come from you, not from a comment.

A Christian testing whether the Gospels are special is not a neutral party.

That is not a smear. It is simply true, and pretending otherwise is worse than admitting it. The person who built this instrument wanted a particular answer.

The project's response is not a denial. It is a set of procedures a hostile reader can check **without trusting anybody**: predictions committed before scoring, falsifiers with numbers fixed in advance, sensitivity analyses declared before the data existed, and a public record of every occasion the procedure caught the person running it.

Say it plainly here: **you are not asking anyone to trust you. You are asking them to check.** Season 7 is entirely about those procedures and the eight times they fired.

The clinical anchor

The near-miss reported by the person who made the error.

Same event as the incident report in episode 12. Same facts, same timeline, same outcome. **Told from the position the other document structurally cannot occupy.**

And notice what makes it valuable, because it is not accuracy. The incident report may well be more accurate. **What the near-miss has is a narrator who knows the mechanism operated**, and that is the entire difference Girard is pointing at, in a form you can hold in your hand.

What would count against this

1. **A myth with a sustained dissenting voice**, which kills the universal negative from episode 12 and takes this episode with it.
2. **The Gospels showing no more dissent language than myth.** The whole distinction is empirical and it can simply fail to appear.
3. **Tragedy failing to sit in the middle.** Girard needs the gradient. **This is the one that actually happens.**

Handing off

Thirteen episodes of a theory with no opposition is not teaching, it is recruitment.

Episode 11 is who says he is wrong, and it comes before the readings on purpose.

Questions

1. If the Gospels score high on all four stereotypes, **what exactly has been shown?** Answer precisely.

2. Girard needs tragedy in the middle. **What is his argument for that?** Is it as strong as the myth-versus-Gospel one?

3. **You are the hostile reader.** List three ways this project could fake a result. Keep the list. Season 7 checks it against what actually happened.

4. "The difference is who is holding the camera." Is that a claim about the texts, or about how we read them? Can it be both?

Collecting thirteen episodes, and noticing what is missing from them

You have now had thirteen episodes of one man's account of human violence, presented by someone who finds it persuasive, with no opposition anywhere in it.

Thirteen episodes of a theory with no opposition is not teaching. It is recruitment, and the audience should be told that this episode exists for that reason.

It comes **before** the readings on purpose. Meet the objections, then go and look at the texts, so that you are reading with both cases in your head.

The clinical anchor, and it is the whole episode

A differential diagnosis.

You do not confirm a diagnosis. You **list the alternatives and rule them out**, and the list goes on the board before the treatment starts. A clinician who considers one diagnosis and finds evidence for it has not diagnosed anything. They have pattern-matched and then collected confirmations.

Everything in episodes 1 to 13 is evidence FOR one hypothesis. Not one minute of it was spent on what else could produce the same pattern. **This episode is the differential.**

The character version: House at the whiteboard. The list goes up first. The whole ritual of that show is that naming the alternatives is the work, and the answer is worthless if the list was never written.

A note on citation, and it is the series' own rule turned inward

This project tiers its own sources. **V** means fetched and checked. **K** means the argument and the person are real but the citation is unverified, so it is a lead and not a fact.

Apply that here. The families of objection below are real and standard. Wherever a specific name and page is needed, **mark it K and go and check before it goes on camera.**

Do not attribute a precise claim to a named scholar from memory. The project caught itself doing exactly that twice and was wrong both times.

Objection 1 — the readings are selective

The commonest and the hardest.

The charge: Girard picks the myths that fit. Greek myth is enormous. Choose forty stories out of thousands and you can demonstrate anything, and nothing in the method tells you which stories were rejected or why.

Why it is serious: it is unanswerable from inside the reading. Producing another good reading is another selected example. You cannot escape a selection problem by selecting more.

This is the objection the entire project exists to answer, and it is why the text tiers were written down and committed before any scoring. Say so here, and then let Seasons 3 and 4 show how badly it went.

Objection 2 — the founding murder has no evidence

The charge: the account requires that real communities really did kill real victims and really did found their institutions on it, in prehistory. There is no archaeological or ethnographic record of this happening.

The strongest form, and state it at its strongest: it is not that the evidence is thin. It is that the claim is **structured so evidence is impossible**, because the mechanism only works while nobody can see it, so any record would necessarily be a record of the concealment.

Notice that this is the same shape as the unfalsifiability charge, and notice where it lands: **squarely on the part of Girard that nothing in this project tests**. Episodes 1 to 5 are exactly that part. **Be honest about it here.**

Objection 3 — the account of sacrifice is contested by people who study sacrifice

The charge: scholars of actual sacrificial systems, including biblical and rabbinic sacrifice, argue that Girard's picture of sacrifice as disguised scapegoating does not match how those systems describe themselves or how they worked. Sacrifice in the Hebrew Bible is largely a system of gift, thanksgiving and purification, and the scapegoat rite of Leviticus 16 is **one rite among many** rather than the key to all of them.

Mark this K. The names to check are the scholars of ancient Judaism who have written directly against Girard. **Fetch them, quote them accurately, or drop the episode.**

Objection 4 — the theological one, and it cuts from inside

The charge, from Christians: if the Cross is primarily **the unveiling of a mechanism**, then Girard has turned salvation into a sociological demonstration. The Cross reveals something rather than doing something.

Why it belongs here rather than in a theology series: it is a live dispute and a Christian viewer will already be feeling it by episode 13. **Say it before they do.**

Objection 5 — the circularity, at its sharpest

Put the four stereotypes next to the theory's own escape route:

- a myth **with** all four stereotypes: the mechanism is visible
- a myth **with none of them**: the mechanism is perfectly concealed, **which is what myth does**

If both outcomes confirm, the theory has predicted nothing. That is the objection in its most brutal form and it is not a strawman.

The only answer is the one this project tried: commit in advance to which texts should score high and which low, and then **lose** if the controls win. Season 3 episode 1 is what

happened.

The device: the five objections, and what answers them

Keep this on screen while you go through them, because the last column is the part a viewer will not otherwise notice.

#	THE OBJECTION	ANSWERED BY THIS PROJECT?
1	the readings are selective	partly. Pre-registration is the whole answer
2	no evidence for the founding murder	no. Untouched
3	the account of sacrifice is contested	no. Untouched
4	the theological objection, from inside	no. Untouched
5	circularity	half. The instrument answers one form of it

Two of five are untouched by six seasons of work, and a viewer who watches all of it should not leave believing otherwise.

The honest position to hold on camera

You are not going to settle these. Say that.

The series does one narrow thing: it takes **objection 1 and objection 5** seriously enough to build something that could have said no, and reports what it said.

Objections 2, 3 and 4 are untouched by anything in the next six seasons, and a viewer who leaves thinking they were answered has been misled.

What would count against this episode

Because an episode listing objections should be checkable like any other.

1. **An objection stronger than these five that is not on the list.** Very likely. **This is one person's reading of the critical literature, not a survey**, and nobody has gone through the Girardian journals to check what the standard replies are or whether they succeed.
2. **One of the five being a strawman.** Objection 2 is the one at risk: "no evidence for the founding murder" is stated here in its strong form, and Girard has a reply about the kind of evidence a prehistoric event could leave. **The reply is not represented here.**
3. **The objections turning out to be answered by the instrument.** They are not. **Nothing in six seasons touches objections 3 or 4 at all**, and the project only ever addresses objection 1 and half of objection 5.

Say that last one out loud. **Two of the five objections in this episode are untouched by everything that follows**, and a viewer who watches the whole series should not leave thinking they were answered.

Handing off

Thirteen episodes of theory and one of opposition. **From here the series stops arguing and starts reading**, because every objection above is easier to hold once you have four

actual texts in your hands.

Episode 15 is the Bacchae**, and it is Girard's own best example, and it is also where his universal negative meets a play containing two dissenters.

Questions

1. **Which of the five is most damaging? Which is most answerable?** They are probably not the same one.

2. Objection 5 says both outcomes confirm. **Write the pre-registration that would break that**, before Season 3 shows you one.

3. Which of these did you already believe before this episode, and which did you have to be told? **The second list is the one that matters.**

4. Run the differential properly: **what else could produce the pattern** the four stereotypes describe, other than Girard's mechanism?

Collecting episode 14

Fourteen episodes of theory and objections, and episode 14 ended by saying that every objection is easier to hold with an actual text in your hands.

So here is the first one, and it is the text Girard leans on hardest.

The format for all four reading episodes

Read a real passage aloud. Locate the four stereotypes **by hand, on camera**, saying which are easy and which are a stretch. Then give the number the instrument later assigns, and **let the mismatch sit unresolved**.

The anchor for all four is the same, and it is clinical: this is the ward round. You have read the notes and the numbers. Now you go and look at the patient, **because the numbers and the patient disagree more often than anyone admits**, and when they do it is usually the number that is measuring something else.

Why this text first

It is Girard's single most important example, the one he returns to across several books. And in this project it fails **four separate pre-registered tests**.

TEST	WHAT IT ASKED	RESULT
Season 3	whole-text saturation	rank 35 of 72
Season 3	does it converge on one passage	p = 0.66
Season 4	does dissent sit near the violence	p = 0.888
Season 4	again, with a corrected null	p = 0.414

Four tests, four operationalizations, four failures. The spine of the entire series is standing inside one play, and the audience should meet the play before they meet the numbers.

The story, for someone who has never read it

Start with the grievance, because it is the crisis and everyone skips it.

Dionysus was born in Thebes. His mother Semele died when Zeus appeared to her in his true form. And Semele's own sisters, **including Agave**, say she made the god up, slept with somebody ordinary, and was killed for the lie.

So the family is split about what happened, and **the god arrives to settle a dispute about his own paternity**. That is where the play opens: not with a monster at the gates but with **a family that cannot agree on a fact**.

Dionysus drives the women of Thebes out onto the mountain, Agave among them.

Pentheus, the young king, Agave's son, treats him as a foreign agitator corrupting the city's women and has him arrested. The prison does not hold.

And then Dionysus offers Pentheus what he wants: **to see**. To go up the mountain and watch. And to get close, Pentheus puts on women's clothes.

The women see him. **They do not see a man.** They see a lion. And they tear him apart with their hands, **his mother leading**, and she carries his head down into the city on a stick, believing it is a hunting trophy, and shows it proudly to her father, who has to walk her, slowly, to what she is holding.

The word for it, and you will hear it for six seasons

Sparagmos. The tearing apart of a victim by a crowd, with hands rather than weapons.

It matters that Greek has a word for this at all. **A culture does not coin a noun for something that happens once**, and Girard's whole case rests on the mechanism being ordinary enough to leave vocabulary behind.

Season 2 episode 9 is the day somebody nearly put that vocabulary in the wrong bucket, and the reason it would have been cheating is the distinction from episode 7: the tearing is what the mob **does**, not what the victim is **accused of**.

What to read aloud

The messenger's speech, and then **the recognition scene** where Cadmus takes Agave apart piece by piece until she sees.

Do not summarise either. Read them.

Now do the four by hand, and be honest about the hard one

STEREOTYPE	PRESENT	WHERE
crisis	yes, and it is everywhere	a family that cannot agree what happened. A mother who cannot recognise her son. A king dressed as a woman. A man seen as an animal. A god taken for a foreigner
crimes	weak	see below
marks	yes	he is the king , the too-high mark from episode 8
violence	yes, in its purest form	the entire female population of the city, with their hands, unanimous

Do the crimes row slowly, because it is the honest problem.

Pentheus is not accused of parricide, or incest, or poisoning, or sorcery. You can argue impiety, and it is a real reading, and it is **much thinner than the other three**.

But the deeper problem is this: the mob does not believe it is executing a criminal at all. It believes it is killing a lion. There is no accusation in the killing, because there is no recognition in it.

In Girard's own best example, the accusation stereotype is the weakest of the four. That is a real observation about the text, made by reading it, and it belongs on camera before any statistics arrive.

And now the thing this play does to episode 12's universal negative

Episode 9 said the differentia is "**no one ever questions the guilt.**" A universal negative. One counterexample kills it.

So look for dissent in the Bacchae. It is there.

Cadmus and Tiresias both try to talk Pentheus into accepting the god. They argue with him directly, on stage, at length. That is a voice against the prevailing verdict.

And Cadmus, at the end, walks Agave out of her delusion, which is the most explicit unmasking of a lynching in Greek tragedy.

So does the play falsify Girard?

Look at where the dissent sits. Cadmus and Tiresias speak **before** the killing. Cadmus speaks **after** it. **Nobody speaks during.** At the moment of collective violence, on the mountain, the unanimity is total.

That is either a rescue or a fudge, and **you should say it is not obvious which.** If dissent counts only when it happens at the exact moment of the killing, the claim is much narrower than it sounded. If dissent counts whenever it appears, this play has it and the universal negative is in trouble.

And be exact about why this is uncomfortable rather than merely open. **The narrowing arrives after the counterexample**, which is the structure of every rescued theory in history. A claim that said "no dissenting voice is ever heard" meets a play with two dissenting voices in it, and the reply is that those do not count because of where they stand in the text.

The reply happens to be right, and it is right for a reason internal to Girard's mechanism: unanimity is what the mechanism requires at the moment it operates, so dissent before and after is exactly what the theory would predict. But notice that the argument would have been available whatever the play contained, which is the property the whole series is watching out for.

Season 4 builds an instrument to ask exactly this question, whether the dissent language sits near the violence language, and the Bacchae comes out at $p = 0.414$. Plant that here, because this episode is where the question is born, and it detonates in Season 4 episode 16, where the answer arrives.

The character anchor

King Kong.

The crowd sees a monster. The film shows you an animal, frightened, in a city it did not choose to enter, and the audience is never allowed to side fully with the people doing the killing.

The mob on the mountain is not lying about what it sees. Agave genuinely believes she is holding a lion. That is the part to hold on to, because it means the accusation stereotype can be almost absent while the mechanism runs at full strength: **you do not need to believe the victim is guilty. You need only to believe he is not one of you.**

The arithmetic to do on screen

The play is **17,180 words**. The killing is one messenger speech, roughly **600 words**.

Divide it. **The lynching is about 3.5% of the play.**

Any measurement that averages across the whole text is **diluting the event by a factor of nearly thirty**. Understanding that single division is understanding half of Season 3.

What would count against this reading

1. **The four being read into the play rather than out of it.** This is objection 1 from episode 14, arriving immediately, on the first text. **The defence is that the tiers were fixed before scoring and the play still failed**, which is a defence about procedure rather than about reading.
2. **Cadmus and Tiresias counting as the dissent Girard says never happens.** If they count, the universal negative is dead on the first text anybody checks. **The narrowing to "during the killing" is what saves it**, and that narrowing is examined rather than assumed above.
3. **The accusation stereotype being genuinely absent rather than weak.** If the mob believes it is killing an animal, there is no accusation at all, and one of the four is missing from Girard's flagship case. **Season 3 episode 1 scores crimes at 0.00 on Pentheus and the reasons are arithmetic**, so this stays open.

Handing off

One text, four stereotypes, one of them weak, and a dissent problem the theory has to narrow its way out of.

Episode 16 is Oedipus the King, which fits the theory better than the Bacchae* does and creates a worse problem while doing it.*

Questions

1. Count the four stereotypes yourself in the messenger speech. **Where do you disagree with the table above?**

2. **What is Pentheus actually accused of?** Answer without using the word "impiety."

3. Cadmus and Tiresias dissent, but not during. **Does that rescue the universal negative or narrow it into uselessness?** Commit before Season 4.

4. If Girard's best example is his weakest on one stereotype, **what does that do to the conjunction claim from episode 10?**

Collecting episode 15

The *Bacchae* is Girard's best example and it came apart in our hands: the accusation stereotype was the weakest of the four, and the dissent turned out to be in the wrong place.

This play is the opposite problem. It is the cleanest fit in existence, and the cleanness is what should worry you.

The story, for someone who has never read it

Thebes is dying. Crops failing, cattle dying, women miscarrying. **The city is under plague and the play opens inside it**, with a delegation begging the king to do something.

The king is **Oedipus**, who saved the city once before by solving the Sphinx's riddle, and who is therefore exactly the man to solve this.

The oracle says: the plague is a pollution. The old king Laius was murdered and the murderer is still here. **Find him and expel him and the city will live.**

So Oedipus opens an investigation. He curses the murderer publicly. He questions the prophet Tiresias, who tells him to stop. He questions his wife's brother. He questions a herdsman.

And the investigation arrives at himself. He killed Laius, who was his father. He married Jocasta, who is his mother. Jocasta hangs herself. Oedipus blinds himself with her brooches and is driven out.

The structural feature nobody points at, and it is episode 3

This is a detective story in which the detective is the criminal.

Episode 3 was about rivals converging until you cannot tell them apart. Here the collapse is not between two people. **It is between two roles inside one person.** The investigator and the culprit, the healer and the pollution, the man looking and the thing being looked for.

The play is a machine for collapsing a distinction, and it runs for fifteen hundred lines doing exactly that. Which is a strange thing to find at the centre of a theory about the collapse of distinctions.

Tiresias is in this play too, and he does the same job he does in the *Bacchae*: he tells a king a true thing the king cannot hear, and he is abused for it. Worth pointing out across the two episodes.

The four, laid out by Sophocles himself

STEREOTYPE AND THE TEXT DOES IT OUT LOUD	
crisis	Thebes under plague . Crops, cattle, childbirth. The first scene , before any plot
crimes	parricide and incest . Two of Girard's four crime families, named, both difference-erasing in exactly his sense
marks	a foreigner who turns out to be native. Lame from infancy, his feet pierced. And the king
violence	expulsion . He is driven out, and the city recovers

Read the opening scene aloud. A city on its knees under plague, begging its king for a cure, **and the cure turns out to be his own expulsion.**

The marks stereotype, all three directions at once

Worth dwelling on. Oedipus is simultaneously:

- **too low**: exposed as an infant, crippled, raised by strangers, a man with no known parents
- **too high**: the king, saviour of the city, married to the queen
- **the outsider**: a Corinthian, or so everyone including him believes

He is every category of victim mark in the theory, in one man, at once. Girard did not have to reach for this. Sophocles handed it to him.

Now run episode 12's causal diagram on it, because the play is strange here

Episode 9's device: myth tells it forwards, Girard reconstructs it backwards.

And this play stages the reconstruction on purpose. We watch the community **assemble** the accusation, live, scene by scene, over the course of an afternoon.

So which is it?

Reading one, for Girard. Look at them building it. The crisis came first, the need for a culprit came second, and the crime was assembled to fit. The play shows you the machinery.

Reading two, against. No. They are not assembling it, they are **discovering** it, with witnesses and evidence and a herdsman who was there. **The investigation is competent and the conclusion is correct.**

Say both and settle neither. The play is the strongest evidence for the theory and the strongest evidence that the theory is reading a detective story as a lynching.

The character anchor

Zuko's Agni Kai with his father, from the accusation side rather than the scar side.

Everybody in that room can give you a lawful account of what happened. A boy spoke out of turn in a war meeting, a challenge was issued under the rules, the duel was fought, the outcome was the outcome. **Every procedural step is correct.** Nobody present is lying about the sequence.

And what actually happened is a father needing a son to be the problem.

That is the two readings of Oedipus, in one scene. You cannot settle it by checking whether the procedure was followed, because the procedure was followed.

The clinical anchor

A case conference that reaches the correct diagnosis and would have reached a diagnosis regardless.

The workup is real. The tests were indicated, the findings are genuine, the conclusion fits. **And the meeting was convened because something had to be decided by the end of it,** and everybody in the room knew that when they walked in.

Being right does not tell you which of those two produced the answer, and the notes will only record the first.

The two numbers

It scores **21.23**, second highest of 72 texts.

And it holds the **highest marks** score in the whole corpus, **9.58**.

Why? Because **marks** is **44%** the word "**king**", and the title character is addressed as king on nearly every page.

The text that best fits the theory is also the single strongest piece of evidence for the objection that the instrument is only detecting royalty.

Sit in that and do not resolve it. Season 4 runs the experiment that settles it, and **the result is not the one this episode makes you expect.**

The thing about Sophocles nobody says

Here is a real problem for the theory, better coming from you than from a comment.

Oedipus is guilty. He did it. He killed his father and married his mother. **The accusation is true.**

Girard's mechanism runs on victims selected arbitrarily, whose guilt is manufactured by the peace that follows. And his cleanest textual fit is a case where the charge is accurate and the investigation is sound.

What does a theory built on arbitrary selection do with a victim who actually did it?

There is an answer available: the theory is about **the crowd's process**, not the victim's record, and a real culprit can be scapegoated too. **Say that, and then say that this project never tests it and the question stays open.**

And it is worth seeing how much that answer gives away, because it is a good answer with a large bill attached. **If guilt is irrelevant to the mechanism, then innocence cannot be the thing that distinguishes a Gospel from a myth**, and the distinction has to live entirely in how the crowd behaves rather than in what the victim did.

That is not a problem invented here. It is Girard's own position, stated in his own sentence, and it is the sentence episode 12 read twice. **Hold on to it**, because the instrument built in Season 3 fills its word-lists mostly with innocence vocabulary

anyway, and **Season 7 episode 4** is where that contradiction finally does visible damage.

What would count against this reading

1. **The play being a detective story rather than a lynching.** Stated above and deliberately not settled. **It is the strongest reading against Girard in the whole season** and it comes from the text that suits him best.
2. **The instrument scoring it highly for the wrong reason.** It holds the highest marks score in the corpus and marks is 44% the word king. **A text whose title character is addressed as king on every page will score high whether or not anything Girardian happens in it.**
3. **Sophocles being one of Girard's sources.** If the stereotype list was built partly by reading this play, then finding all four in it is circular. **Nobody has traced which texts Girard had in front of him when he wrote chapter 2**, and until somebody does, question 4 below has no answer.

Handing off

Two masterpieces, two readings, and in both cases the poetry and the structure are inseparable from the content.

Episode 17 reads the opposite of that, and the opposite turns out to be a natural experiment nobody set up on purpose.

Questions

1. **The accusation against Oedipus is true.** Does the mechanism still work? Does Girard need the victim innocent, or only need the crowd not to know?

2. The play stages the assembly of an accusation. **Assembly or discovery?** Give the strongest case for each.

3. Highest marks in the corpus and the reason is one word. **Genre signal or victim mark? Commit now**, before Season 4.

4. Sophocles states all four explicitly. **Is that evidence for Girard, or evidence that Girard built the list partly from this play?**

Collecting episodes 15 and 16

Two masterpieces. Two texts where every word is doing work, where the poetry and the structure and the irony are inseparable from the content.

This episode reads the opposite of that, and the opposite turns out to be a natural experiment nobody set up on purpose.

What it is

The *Bibliotheca*. A systematic prose summary of **the whole of Greek myth**, compiled around the first or second century AD.

Not a story. **A catalogue of stories.**

Everything is in it: the theogony, the houses of Argos and Thebes and Athens, the labours, the war, the returns. All of it, at speed, one after another, with no description, no scene-setting, no dialogue worth the name, no digression, and no opinion.

Read a page aloud and let the audience hear the speed

A character is born, marries, kills somebody, is transformed, and dies **in four lines**. Then the next one. Then the next.

Every sentence is an event. There is no connective tissue, because connective tissue is what a summary removes.

The character anchor

A Wikipedia plot summary.

Everybody has read one. In episode nine, X kills Y; Z discovers the betrayal and leaves. Same events, same order, same characters, **and none of the thing you actually watched it for.**

Now use it as a test, because that is what this episode is going to do with Apollodorus. **Take something you love and read its plot summary.** Whatever survives the summary was in the events. Whatever evaporates was in the telling, and you have just separated the two with no theory and no instrument.

The Bibliotheca is Greek myth's plot summary, written eighteen centuries before anybody thought of doing that on purpose.

And here is why this text is worth an episode

Apollodorus is what myth looks like with the storytelling taken out.

Same events. Same characters. Same crimes and killings and expulsions. **The plot without the telling.**

Which sets up a question the corpus can actually answer:

Are Girard's four stereotypes in the EVENTS, or in the TELLING?

If they are in the events, they should survive the removal of the poetry. **If they are an artifact of tragic rhetoric, they should vanish here.**

Nobody designed that experiment. It is sitting in the corpus by accident, which is worth saying out loud, because a natural experiment is the most valuable thing a corpus can contain and **you only ever get one by noticing it.** Nobody could have funded this. Nobody could have commissioned a poet to write a version of Greek myth with the poetry removed. **Somebody in the first century did it for reasons of his own, and the control group has been sitting on a shelf ever since.**

The answer, and it cuts two ways

Mythography scores **13.95**. Tragedy scores **13.88**.

A dead heat. Strip out the poetry, the meter, the irony, the choral odes and the characterisation, and the stereotype vocabulary is **exactly as dense**.

Reading one, and this is the one the project took. It is a **confound**. A rate per thousand words rewards plot per word, and Apollodorus is nothing but plot per word, so it scores like a tragedy without being one. Here is the measurement that supports it, taken much later with a **neutral** event-word list containing nothing Girardian:

GENRE	NEUTRAL EVENT-WORDS PER 1000
MYTHOGRAPHY	28.65
EPIC	22.68
OVID	21.73
TRAGEDY	21.45
CONTROL	20.77

It is the densest narrative prose in the corpus by a wide margin, and that is a real finding.

Reading two, which the project never made, and it is worth saying on camera.

The stereotypes **survived the removal of the telling**. If they were a feature of tragic rhetoric, a mood produced by choral lament and heightened diction, they should have thinned out in a bare summary and they did not.

That is arguably evidence FOR Girard, and nowhere in eight rounds does anybody say so. The tie was recorded as a problem. **It can also be read as the stereotypes being structural rather than stylistic**, which is exactly what the theory claims.

Say both. **Do not pick.** And note out loud that the project only ever wrote down the unflattering reading, which is its own kind of bias and worth noticing in a series about bias.

And notice which direction that bias runs, because it is not the direction anybody warns you about. The whole apparatus of pre-registration exists to stop a believer flattering his own theory. Here the believer had a result that favoured him sitting in front of him, and filed it as a confound, and never wrote the other sentence down.

That is not a virtue. **A researcher who systematically records one reading of his ambiguous results is biased whichever way he leans**, and being biased against yourself is still a way of not looking.

The clinical anchor

A discharge summary against the full notes.

Every diagnosis is in the summary. Every drug, every procedure, every date. **What is not in it is the reasoning.** The two days somebody was unsure, the differential that was considered and dropped, the conversation that changed the plan.

Read a hundred summaries and you will know what happened to a hundred patients and almost nothing about how medicine is practised. **The events survive the compression. The thinking does not**, and that is the experiment sitting in this corpus by accident.

And the twist that stops either reading being comfortable

Across all 73 texts, the correlation between event density and the Girard score is **negative**. $r = -0.243$, $p = 0.040$.

So density does not generally inflate the score. It deflates it. Epic is dense and scores low.

The confound is real **for mythography specifically** and **unproven as a general mechanism**. Say plainly that the explanation does not exist. **This is an open problem in the project, not a solved one**, and pretending otherwise would be the exact thing this series is about.

What would count against this reading

1. **The tie being too small to interpret in either direction.** It is 0.07, and **Season 3 episode 8 shows it sits inside a 17% noise floor**. Both readings offered above may be explanations of nothing, and that episode is where this one gets taken apart.
2. **Density explaining it entirely.** Measured, real, and it would make the survival of the stereotypes an artifact rather than evidence.
3. **The corpus imbalance.** Mythography is 8 files against epic's 36, for reasons Season 2 episode 4 shows have nothing to do with antiquity. **Nobody has reweighted and re-run.**

Handing off

Three texts read: a tragedy, a second tragedy, and a summary with the poetry taken out.

Episode 18 reads the text that is supposed to score low, and it produces the most instructive false positive in the entire project.

Questions

1. Read a page. **Would you call it literature?** Does the answer matter for whether it belongs in the corpus?
-

2. **Are the stereotypes in the events or in the telling?** The tie is evidence. Which way do you read it, and why did the project only record one direction?

3. Densest prose, top score, **and density correlates negatively overall**. Reconcile all three.

4. **What would you divide by, if not total words?**

Collecting episode 17, and closing the season

Episode 14 read myth with the telling stripped out. **This episode reads the text that is supposed to score low**, and it produces the most instructive false positive in the entire project.

A control is a text you expect to fail. If your instrument cannot fail anywhere, you learned that in Season 2 episode 1: it is not measuring.

A check that cannot fail prints reassurance. That sentence is the spine of this whole series, and a control group is the cheapest way anybody has found to buy a check that can.

And the *Odyssey* is the right choice for one, which is worth a sentence before the numbers arrive. It is long, it is canonical, it is full of violence and kings and crisis, **and nothing in it is a persecution in Girard's sense**. Nobody is selected arbitrarily by a community and killed to end a crisis. So it is a text that ought to be rich in every surface feature the instrument looks at and poor in the thing the instrument is for, which is exactly what you want a control to be.

The finding

The *Odyssey*, split into its 24 books and scored separately:

BOOK	SCENE	CRISIS	CRIMES	MARKS	VIOLENCE	TOTAL
7	Odysseus welcomed at Alcinous' palace	0.30	0.00	6.21	0.00	6.51
18	Irus the beggar	0.00	0.00	5.49	2.15	7.64
22	the slaughter of the suitors	1.09	0.22	0.22	4.14	5.67

Read book 7 aloud, because nobody will believe it otherwise

It is a dinner party.

A shipwrecked stranger arrives at a palace. He is received. He is bathed and given clean clothes. He is seated, fed, and asked politely who he is. The king and queen treat him with perfect courtesy. He tells them about his voyage.

Zero violence. Nothing bad happens to anybody at all.

And it outscores every tragedy in the corpus on the victim-marks bucket.

Meanwhile book 22, in which one man kills a hall full of a hundred people and then hangs the serving women, ranks **seventh**.

Why

"King" and "queen" saturate a palace scene, because everyone in it either is one or is addressing one. And `marks` is 44% the word `king`.

The least persecution-shaped narrative in Greek literature contains the most persecution-shaped-looking passage in the corpus. That sentence is the episode.

The character anchor

A smoke alarm going off because of toast.

Nothing is broken. The alarm is not faulty, it has not been miswired, and it is not being oversensitive in any way its manufacturer would apologise for. **It detects smoke, and toast makes smoke.** Every step of its reasoning is correct.

And notice which repairs are on offer. **You cannot fix it by making it ignore smoke,** because smoke is the thing it is for. You cannot fix it by adding a rule about toast, because the next false alarm will be a shower or a candle or a hot pan, and there is no finite list.

king is the toast. It genuinely is a victim mark, for the reasons episode 8 established, and a palace genuinely is full of kings, and the detector is working exactly as designed while telling you something absurd.

The clinical anchor

A tumour marker that is also raised in pregnancy.

The assay is specific to the molecule it names. It is not cross-reacting, it is not contaminated, and the elevated result is a true measurement of a substance that is genuinely present at that level. **Every step is correct and the patient does not have cancer.**

Notice which repairs that rules out. You cannot lower the threshold, because the value really is high. You cannot recalibrate, because nothing is miscalibrated. **The molecule is a real marker that is not exclusive to the disease,** and the only fix available is to stop reading it on its own and require it alongside something pregnancy does not produce.

That is the minimum, arriving one season early.

And the instrument gets the whole poem exactly right

This is what makes it interesting rather than merely embarrassing.

Across the 76-text corpus, the *Odyssey* holds **three of the four lowest scores**, with book 5 at **2.35** against a corpus top of 23.18.

So the instrument reads the poem correctly and one chapter of it catastrophically wrongly, **and the same word causes both.** king is why the poem scores low overall, because most of it happens at sea. And king is why book 7 scores absurdly high, because that part happens in a palace.

What saves it, and this is where Season 2 is going

Score book 7 by the **minimum** of the four buckets instead of the sum, and it scores **0.00** and vanishes, because its **crimes** bucket is empty.

The conjunction requirement from episode 10 kills the false positive automatically, without anyone noticing it or patching anything.

That is the strongest argument for the minimum in the whole project, and it is genuinely good reasoning. **Season 3 episode 2 is where the minimum falls apart for a completely different reason** that has nothing to do with this.

What would count against this episode

1. **Book 7 being a fluke worth no attention.** One passage out of twenty-four, in one poem. **The counter is that the fix it motivates is the one Season 2 adopts as its primary metric**, so a fluke would mean the metric was chosen on the strength of an accident.
2. **The false positive being the lexicon's fault after all.** If **king** is a genre signal rather than a victim mark, this episode is not a lesson about metrics at all, it is a lesson about a broken word-list, and no clever combination rule repairs it. **Episode 7 left that question open on purpose and Season 4 settles it.**
3. **The whole-poem result being an artifact of length.** The *Odyssey* holds three of the four lowest scores in the corpus and it is also one of the longest texts in it. **Nobody has checked whether long texts score low generally**, which would explain the poem's position without any of the reasoning above.

Closing the season

Eighteen episodes. A theory, its objections, and four texts.

And not one number has been tested. Everything quoted in this season is a measurement that a later season will either defend or destroy, and the instrument that produced them has not been built yet.

That is worth stating flatly rather than as a modest disclaimer. **Every figure in these eighteen episodes came out of a program whose construction the audience has not seen**, written by somebody with a preferred answer, on a corpus assembled by a script. A viewer who has been persuaded of anything by this season has been persuaded too early.

Season 2 builds it. And Season 2's first episode is about the only accusation that matters: that none of this can be wrong.

Questions

1. Read book 7 and **count king and queen yourself**. Is the instrument wrong, or is the word list wrong? Those are not the same answer.
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2. Book 22 is a massacre and ranks seventh. **What is it missing that the theory requires?** Be specific.
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3. A control is a text you expect to fail. **Name three more you would put in**, and say what each one controls for.
-

4. The minimum fixes this. Season 3 breaks the minimum. **Is there a fix that survives both?** Try before you are shown one.
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Runtime

Do not trust a runtime estimate taken from this document's length. Run `audit.py`. It reports the speakable word count per episode with tables, code and question blanks stripped, which is the only number that predicts anything. Divide by 135.

The character anchors, gathered

Keep this table. It is the season's actual delivery system.

CONCEPT	CHARACTER	WHY IT FITS
mimetic desire	Vegeta	wants to be stronger than Goku, not strong
mimetic desire, second angle	Salieri	hears a verdict on himself, not music
model becomes rival	Griffith and Guts	the inversion happens in one scene, nobody chose it
model becomes rival, gentler	Ippo and Miyata	the promise is both the goal and the obstacle
the double bind	Zuko and Ozai	approval is granted only by the person blocking it
model and rival are one	Tyler Durden	literally the same person, invisible from inside
doubles	Naruto and Sasuke	mirrored moves, symmetrical frame, two statues
doubles, older audience	Light and L	each ends up doing the other's job
the crisis	Squid Game dormitory	self-sustaining, organisers do nothing
the crisis, famous	Lord of the Flies	the conch is a difference-making device
the scapegoat	Zuko's banishment	the room calls it justice and is not lying
the crisis bucket, ep 6	Agent Smith	the bucket that measures lost difference lost its own
crimes that erase difference	Light Yagami	dissolves judge and criminal
crimes, identity version	Tom Ripley	can occupy another man's life undetected
marks, too low	Zuko's scar	visible, permanent, inside his own family
marks, too high	BoJack	famous, and the public turning is real and mechanical
violence, and its unanimity, ep 9	"I am Spartacus"	the negative image of the whole mechanism
the accusation, ep 13	Zuko's Agni Kai	every procedural step correct, and it is a father needing a culprit
the false positive, ep 17	a smoke alarm at toast	nothing is broken and there is no finite list of exceptions
myth as the crowd's account	The Usual Suspects	coherent, complete, built by the beneficiary

One episode per stereotype, from episode 6. Crisis, crimes, marks, violence. They were two episodes until it became clear the four **fail differently**, and pairing them hid the only thing worth comparing: 60% `death`, 12% `murder`, 44% `king`, 21% `blood`.

What this season deliberately does not do

It does not test anything. It does not defend Girard. It does not say whether the theory is true.

It plants six numbers that later episodes detonate. Keep them visible:

